Sunday, February 11, 2024
Magh 28, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Shillathwo Dwitiya

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 57 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing a programme organised to celebrate Sonam Lhosar, the New Year Day of the Tamang Community at Tundikhel, Kathmandu on Saturday.

Implementation of federalism is my top priority: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the political forces and leadership fighting for identity and rights should come together.

Speaking at a programme organised on the occasion of Sonam Lhosar, Prime Minister Prachanda said that with the support of classes, castes and communities that support identity and rights, a qualitative leap can be made by implementing federalism.

"I would like to make a special request from this platform, that you get to know the political forces and leadership that are fighting for identity and rights, and rally around them will be strong again, and the remaining tasks of the movement will be completed," he said.

Recalling that when he was the Prime Minister for the second time, important works like determining the 753 local levels, conducting local-level elections and establishing the offices in line with federalism were accomplished. He clarified that implementation of federalism was a top priority during his third term as the Prime Minister of the country.

Two meetings of the National Coordinating Council have been completed during this period, and the report on work detailing is in the final process of revision, said PM Prachanda.

Prime Minister Prachanda said, "I have attached great importance to the passing of federal laws such as the Federal Civil Services Act, the Federal Education Act, the Federal Police Act and others. The police adjustment process has reached its final stage."

Stating that tens of thousands of brave warriors sacrificed for the promulgation of the constitution that established identity and rights, he urged, "All of us must be serious that only by strengthening the revolutionary power, party and leadership, the progressive implementation of the constitution and the foundation of more rights can be established."

EFFORTS BEING MADE TO PROMOTE TRADE IN BORDER AREAS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the development and trade promotion in the border areas will be strengthened through diplomatic initiatives in the coming days.

Inaugurating the 24th annual general meeting of the Nepal Trans Himalayan Trade Association on Saturday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that he was well aware of the need to prepare the necessary infrastructure for trade and business promotion.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that he had paid special attention to the operation of the international and commercial border between Nepal and China after leading the government for the third time, adding that there has been ease in traffic and economic activities at the borders of the northern region, including Tatopani.

During his visit to China in September last year, there were adequate discussions on the development of the border area, the problems of the residents of the border area, the role to be played by the Chinese government and the support to be provided, said the Prime Minister.

"During my visit to China, I had an in-depth discussion about the role to be played in the development of this region through the joint efforts of Nepal-China," said PM Prachanda, "The two countries discussed the transfer of certificates for the production of the northern mountainous region of Nepal. This will have qualitative implications in the cross-border trade promotion."

The Prime Minister appreciated the contribution of the Nepal Trans Himalayan Trade Association for managing cross-border trade.

Generating 28,500 MW by 2035 looks ambitious, not unattainable

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

Nepal's hydropower development remained frustratingly sluggish for more than a century. It generated a meager 750 MW since the establishment of the first-ever 500-KW Chandrajyoti hydroelectric power station in Pharping in 1911.

But it gathered momentum in the last decade, thanks to conducive government policy, increasing private sector investment, availability of foreign markets and shift to clean energy.

Nepali people were compelled to face 18-hour-a-day load-shedding until a decade ago. Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) declared the nation as load-shedding-free only in May 2018.

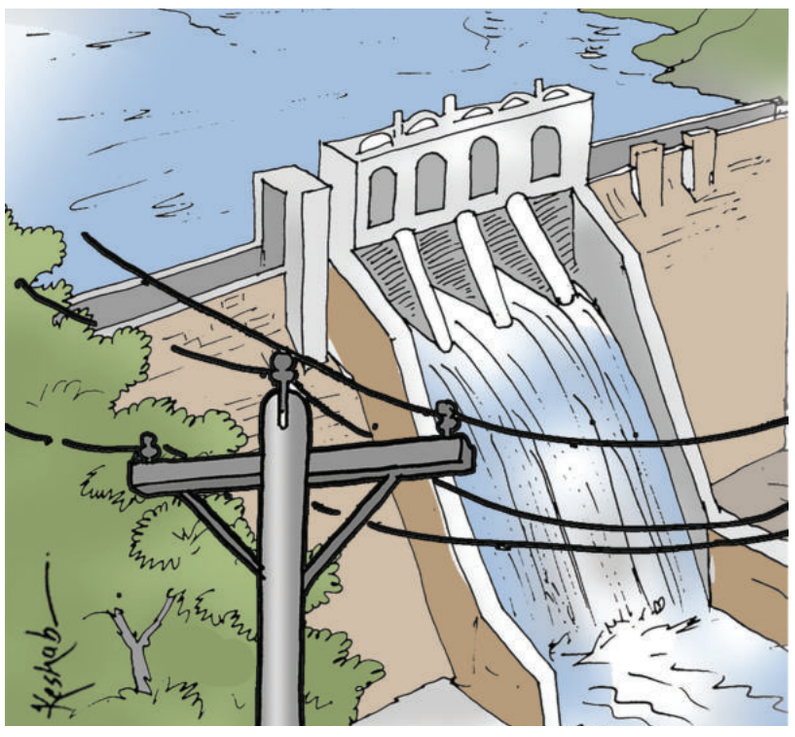
However, in the past few years, power generation increased rapidly and installed capacity reached almost 3,000 MW. In the meantime, Nepal started exporting power to India in rainy season.

Encouraged by the progress made over the years, the government has set a target to generate 28,500 MW in next 12 years, and has been working to prepare bases to achieve the target.

Recently, Nepal signed a long-term power trade agreement with India to export 10,000 MW of electricity to India in the next 10 years. This agreement has pleased the private sector and encouraged domestic and foreign investors to invest in Nepal's hydropower sector.

In its latest Energy Development Roadmap and Action Plan, the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation has set an ambitious target of generating 28,500 MW of hydropower by 2035. Out of that, 13,500 MW of electricity is planned to be consumed within the country and the remaining 15,000 MW will be exported to India and Bangladesh. This target has led to a debate about whether it can be achieved.

However, they said that genuine efforts from all sectors, including government, ministries, private sector as well as banks and financial institutions were needed to achieve the target.



TRN SPECIAL

However, hydropower experts have claimed that achieving the target of generating 28,500 MW of electricity by 2035 and exporting 10,000 MW to India in the next 10 years is possible.

Former Secretary at the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Suman Prasad Sharma said that 28,500 MW power could be generated in the next 12 years if the government facilitates policies for mobilising domestic and foreign investments and resolving the existing problems, which surfaced while developing a hydropower project.

Recalling a bitter fact that no hydropower project was completed in time in 112 years' history of power generation in Nepal, he stressed the need for timely solutions to the problems related to land acquisition, forest and others, which surface while building hydropower and transmission lines.

According to Pradeep Kumar Thike, Deputy Managing Director of NEA, the government has set a target to generate 28,500 MW by 2035 based on the present scenario of power generation, the under construction projects, the mega projects advanced by the government and private sectors and the increasing interest of the foreign investors in developing clean energy.

The installation capacity of hydropower in the country has almost reached 3000 MW, out of that, around 2,214 MW electricity has been produced from the hydropower projects developed by the private sector.

About 131 hydropower projects with a capacity of 3,397 MW are now in the under construction phase. About 138 hydropower projects with capacity of 3,615 MW are in the stage of financial management and 258 projects with the capacity of 19,623 MW are in the various stages of construction by taking licenses.

Currently, construction process of large reservoir and semi-reservoir hydropower projects-- 1,200 MW Budhigandaki and 635 MW Dudh Koshi reservoir hydroelectric projects, 1,063 MW Upper Arun semi-reservoir and 417 MW Nalgad hydropower-- projects are advancing. Other hydropower projects, including 900 MW Arun III are also under construction phase.

» SEE PAGE 6

Minister Saud stresses stability in Indian Ocean

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

Minister for Foreign Affairs, Narayan Prakash Saud, has stressed the stability and sustainability of the Indian Ocean for landlocked countries like Nepal.

Addressing the seventh Indian Ocean Conference held in Perth, Australia on Saturday, he underscored the importance of the Indian Ocean for Nepal in reaching the international market and highlighted the importance of stability and sustainability there.

Stating that there is an organic link between the Himalayas and the Ocean, FM Saud underlined that ocean and mountain issues should be dealt with in an integrated and holistic manner, informed the Embassy of Nepal in Canberra, Australia.

» SEE PAGE 6

Make good governance foundation of prosperity: Minister Sharma



RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 10

Minister for Communications and Information Rekha Sharma has said good governance should be made a foundation of prosperity.

Inaugurating the second general assembly of FNCCI Bagmati Province in the capital on Saturday, Minister Sharma viewed good governance in all sides, including government and private sectors, could prop up efforts to economic prosperity.

She, however, said, "It is true we are facing resource confines, but more worrying is nonuse of available resources." Minister Sharma also admitted that there are irregularities and leakages in government sector, while private sectors are also dodging tax and misusing public property.

According to her, government is mandated to bring meaningful change in people's life with prosperity by fortifying the changed political system. "Changing people's life is elevating their economic condition in particular.

» SEE PAGE 6

Koshi Province lacks disabled-friendly structures

BY NAWARAJ KATTEL
Biratnagar, Feb. 10

People with disabilities have been facing challenges while receiving services at hospitals and offices of the local level governments in Koshi Province. When the National Federation of the Disabled conducted an accessibility audit on 22 governmental offices in four districts of the Koshi Province, it was found that the majority of the offices do not have accessible physical infrastructure for persons with disabilities.

Krishna Mandal, 35, of Shanti Chowk in Biratnagar Metropolitan City-1, is disabled by birth as he was born without both legs. He arrived at the Koshi Hospital, Biratnagar, to meet the medical superintendent. Unfortunately, there was no accessible physical infrastructure for him to visit the office of the medical superintendent, located on the first floor. However, Mandal reached the office by crawling on the staircase.

The story of Mandal represents challenges faced by the disabled in their everyday life. Chairman of the National Federation of the Disabled in Koshi Province, Nabin Dhungel, said that it would have been easy for the disabled to receive services if the buildings had included disabled-friendly physical infrastructures.

He said, "The people's representatives like ministers, mayors, deputy mayors, chairpersons and others who are responsible towards addressing the issues of the people do not need to set up their offices on the first or second floor.

If the buildings don't have disabled-friendly physical infrastructure, they could shift their offices to the ground floor." Additionally, implementation of the "Accessible Physical Infrastructure and Communication Services Directive for Persons with Disabilities 2013" seems to be very weak, he said.

Earlier, the National Federation of the Disabled had conducted an accessibility audit on 10 offices in Biratnagar, Damak Municipality of Jhapa and Koshi Rural Municipality of Sunsari. The structures included the High Court Biratnagar, Koshi Hospital, Ministry



of Social Development, Ministry of Road Infrastructure and Urban Development, National Human Rights Commission, District Administration Office Morang, District Police Office Morang, District Government Attorney's Office and Biratnagar Metropolitan City.

Many offices were found lacking disabled-friendly physical infrastructures. Santosh Pandit, who has been monitoring accessible physical infrastructures in Koshi under the National Federation of the Disabled in Koshi Province, said that a few offices had started making their buildings accessible to the disabled. He said that the report of the audit was sent to the concerned offices and the Ministry of Social Development of Koshi Province.

According to the report, the Ministry of Road Infrastructure and Urban Development has made the office premises accessible in recent times.

He said, "After the audit, some offices have been improved, but attention has not been paid to creating structures based on the instructions."

The accessibility audit suggested that the office buildings could be made accessible for the disabled at a low cost without spending much.

The National Federation of the Disabled had also organised training for engineers of local bodies of Koshi Province to make the new structures fully accessible to the physically challenged persons. Similarly, the preparations were underway to bring together the four districts for such training in the coming days.

MINISTER BHUSAL PLEDGES TO ADDRESS CONCERNS OF MILK PRODUCERS

RSS
Bharatpur (Chitwan), Feb. 10

Minister for Agriculture and Livestock Development, Dr. Beduram Bhusal has said that the government is committed to addressing the issues of dairy producers. Talking to the media at Bharatpur Airport on Friday, the Minister said dairy farmers were facing market-related issues for the products.

The Minister who was here to inaugurate a national tea exhibition in Chitwan, the Minister said, "This season is significant for milk production. He suggested that the surplus milk production could be strategically reserved as power and butter for future use. He assured that the ongoing shortage of market for milk would be resolved after mid-February. Minister Bhusal also pledged to expedite the clearance of dues owed to farmers promptly.

Farmers in Chitwan have reportedly gone unpaid for three months. The Chitwan Milk Industry has remained closed due to a shortage of markets.

BFIs deposit and credit disbursement increases

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10



The deposit mobilisation at Banks and Financial Institutions (BFIs) increased by 6.6 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24 compared to the same period of the last fiscal year.

According to the latest macroeconomic and financial report of Nepal Rastra Bank, the deposit collection at BFIs increased by Rs. 377.07 billion (6.6 per cent) in the review period compared to an increase of Rs. 215.14 billion (4.2 per cent) in the corresponding period of the previous year.

On a y-o-y basis, deposits at BFIs expanded by 14.9 per cent in mid-January 2024. The share of demand, saving and fixed deposits in total deposits stood at 6.8 per cent, 26.8 per cent and 59.9 per cent respectively in mid-January 2024.

Such shares were 7.8 per cent, 25.6 per cent and 60.3 per cent respectively a year ago. The share of institutional deposits in total deposits of BFIs stood at 36.6 per cent in mid-January 2024. Such a share was 36.6 per cent in mid-January 2023.

Similarly, the private sector credit from BFIs has increased by 4 per cent during the review period as compared to same period in last fiscal year. The private sector credit from BFIs increased by Rs.192.64 billion (4 per cent) in the review period compared to an increment of Rs. 137.33 billion (3 per cent) in the corresponding period of the previous year.

On y-o-y basis, credit to the private sector from BFIs increased by 4.9 per cent in mid-January 2024. The shares of private sector credit from BFIs to non-financial corporations and household stand at 63.2 per cent and 36.8 per cent respectively in mid-January 2024.

Such shares were 64.9 per cent and 35.1 per cent a year ago. In the review period, private sector credit from commercial banks, development banks and finance companies increased by 4 per cent, 4.4 per cent and 2.4 per cent respectively.

In the review period, out of the total outstanding credit of the BFIs, 11.4 per cent is against the collateral of current assets (such as agricultural and non-agricultural products) and 67.7 per cent against land and building. Such ratios were 12.2 per cent and 67.2 per cent respectively a year ago.

In the review period, outstanding loans of BFIs to the agriculture sector loan increased by 1.1 per cent, the production sector by 8 per cent, construction sector by 4.1 per cent, transportation, communication and public sector by 10.6 per cent, wholesale and retail sector by 2 per cent, service industry sector by 4.5 per cent and consumable sector by 7 per cent, said the report.

In the review period, term loans extended by BFIs increased by 13.2 per cent, cash credit loans by 27.5 per cent, trust receipt (import) loans by 5.8 per cent, real estate loans (including residential personal home loans) by 4.7 per cent, and margin nature loan by 10.5 per cent.

However, the overdraft loan extended by BFIs decreased by 41 per cent (mainly due to the reclassification of loans from the last year) and the hire purchase loan decreased by 19.9 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year.

YARIS CROSS HYBRID ELECTRIC CAR LAUNCHED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

United Traders Syndicate Pvt. Ltd., the official distributor of Toyota cars in Nepal, has announced the launch of Yaris Cross Hybrid Electric car in Nepal on Friday.

The Rs. 12.2 million new Yaris Cross measures 4310 mm in length, 1770 mm in width and 1615 mm in height. It has a 2620 mm long wheelbase and 18 inch tires.

Toyota has given the new Yaris Cross headlights with automatic high beam, LED DRLs, LED fog lights and connected LED taillights. For the first time, the company has also given multi-colour ambient light in this model.

Being a hybrid powertrain, it comes with an electric motor and a 4.3 ampere hour battery pack. E-CVT gearbox can be found in vehicles with regenerative braking system.

Its displacement is 1500 cc, four cylinder dual VVT-I engine and the ground clearance is 210 mm. It features lithium-ion battery; panoramic glass roof, 10.1-inch infotainment system, 7-inch multi-information display, 6 speakers, and a panoramic 360-degree camera, as well as electric parking brake, auto hold.

Bay leaf transaction increases in Dhanusha



PHOTO: BIJAY SAH/TRN

Consumers' curiosity on bay leaf at Dhanushadham Fair.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhalkebar, Feb. 10

A month-long Makarsankranti fair is held in Dhanushadham which is 18 kilometers northeast of Janakpurdham, both domestic and foreign tourists visit this month-long fair held in the month of Magh. Pilgrims from Dhanusha, Mahottari, Siraha, Saptari, Sindhuli and Indian border regions come to observe this religious fair.

Even though the fair has lost its originality, the transaction of bay leaves has increased significantly. Mukesh Kumar Thakur, a local media person said that trading of bay leaves has increased in the fair, surpassing the transaction of their other items.

He said that the bay leaves, which are used in cooking and domestic medicine, are the main attraction of this fair organised every year. "Most of the people who come to the fair buy bay leaves. Apart from that, the business of sweet potatoes, Dhupi and agricultural and domestic tools looked good," he said.

Advisor of the Dhanushadham Fair Management Committee Chalitar Mahato, who is also a bay leaf trader, said that there has been a turnover of bay leaf worth Rs. 10 million to date. Stating that they are purchasing bay leaf from the Udayapur district, he said, "Around 2,400 quintals of bay leaf have been sold."

It is believed that an additional bay leaf worth Rs. 10 million will be sold. He informed that more than one ton of bay leaves was sold last year as well.

Sarita Mahato of Dhalkebar said that she bought bay leaves at the fair because of the quality and the aroma they possess, and they are cheaper compared to other places, so she purchased bay leaves enough for a year. Stating that there is a separate market for bay leaves, he said that more than 20 retailers and wholesalers are doing business separately at the fair.

US ANNOUNCES $5 BILLION TO RESEARCH COMPUTER CHIPS

AP
Washington, Feb. 10

US administration on Friday will announce the investment of $5 billion in a public-private consortium aimed at supporting research and development in advanced computer chips.

The National Semiconductor Technology Center is being funded through the CHIPS and Science Act. That 2022 law aims to reinvigorate the computer chip sector within the United States through targeted government support. "We need to be building for the future and that means making investments in R&D," Commerce Secretary Gina Raimondo said to reporters in a call previewing the financial commitment.

The center would help to fund the design and prototyping of new chips, in addition to training workers for the sector. Companies say they need a skilled workforce in order to capitalize on the separate $39 billion being provided by the government to fund new and expanded computer chip plants.

Labor Department data say that about 375,000 people are employed in the production of computer chips with an average income of $82,830.

Industry leaders and stakeholders plan to gather at the White House on Friday for the announcement, according to government officials.

MAN gets new leadership under Mohan Raj Ojha



PHOTO: TRN

Newly elected executive committee members of MAN.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

Management Association of Nepal (MAN) has got a new working committee led by Mohan Raj Ojha, founder of Growth Sellers Pvt. Ltd. The 43rd Annual General Meeting of MAN on Friday evening unanimously elected a 17-member working committee for the next two-year term.

Suman Pokharel of Gobal IME Bank has been elected first Vice-President and Hema Adhikari of Mashreq Bank as the second VP. Similarly, academician Indra Shrestha has elected to the post of the General Secretary and Social Security Fund's Executive Director, Kabi Raj Adhikari has been elected as treasurer.

Members of the new working committee are Dharmananda Awasthi, Anu Joshi Shrestha, Krishna Prasad Acharya, Kishore Dhungana, Madhu Paudel, Jitendra Dhital, Surya Prasad Silwal, Ashok Sherchan, Chunk Chettri, Rajesh Kumar Panda, Ajay Kumar Mishra and Mahesh Swar.

On the occasion, MAN felicitated Gokarna Awasthi, Director General of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI), Management of the Year Award. Likewise, Aarati Chataut received Women manager Recognition Award, and Manoj Poudel received Youth Icon Recognition Award while Padma Lal Shrestha was conferred with the Life Time Achievement Award.

Governor of the Nepal Rastra Bank, Maha Prasad Adhikari, felicitated them with the respective award. He also highlighted the importance of good managers in the growth of business, institutions and economy.

BULLION
(Rs. 10 gms)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 101,595
Worked Gold	: Rs. 101,125
Silver	: Rs. 1,192

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,096.32
Total Amount	: 3,212,283,453.63
No. of Share	: 9,171,710

Finnair asks passengers voluntarily weigh themselves

AP
Copenhagen (Denmark), Feb. 10

Almost everything that gets onto a commercial plane — fuel, checked-in baggage, cargo and meals — is weighed. For passengers and their cabin bags, most airlines use average data.

But Finland's national carrier Finnair said Friday that it started asking passengers this week voluntarily and anonymously hop onto a scale with their hand luggage at the country's main airport in Helsinki, the airline said Friday. The aim is to get their own figures.

"We will need data for both winter season and for summer season — in winter season people typically have heavier clothing, which impacts weights," Finnair spokeswoman Päivyt Tallqvist told The Associated Press, adding that the survey would last until May.

Passengers boarding onto European and long-haul flights won't be "penalized for their weight," and "the numbers are kept discreet, away from prying eyes," she added. So far, about 800 people have joined the survey, and those who agree to take part receive a small gift — a reflective baggage tag, Tallqvist said.

Airlines can either use official data by the European Union Aviation Safety Agency, known as EASA, or do their own standard weights measurements, Tallqvist said. Finnair has chosen the latter, but safety authorities require that the survey is renewed every five years.



PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

Simkot Airport after heavy snowfall. Flights were obstructed for several days due to inappropriate atmosphere here.

Free bachelor education to Ilam women



PHOTO: PREM ADHIKARI/TRN

Women pose in a frame after they participate in an interaction in Ilam.

BY PREM ADHIKARI
Ilam, Feb. 10

Out of 10 municipalities in Ilam, Suryodaya Municipality has distinctive features. It has made considerable efforts to improve educational standards and make it accessible for its denizens.

The municipality has been providing free bachelor's education to women to discourage the practice where women discontinue their education after getting married. For the past four years, the municipality has been providing 100 per cent scholarships to women in Karfok Multiple Campus with the slogan 'The Municipality Desire of Education to Daughters and Daughters-in-Law.'

The municipality had done agreement with the campus to provide graduate education to 40 daughters-in-law in the current academic session. To date, 27 out of 197 participants of the educational programme have graduated from the campus, informed Campus Chief Gopal Kattel.

According to Yognidhi Bhattarai, head of the education, youth and sports department, the municipality had arranged for 100-day employment for the students who graduated. Additionally, they have also been included in the educational programme for the preparation of civil service examinations.

He said that arrangements had been made for women to BBA, BBM, B.Ed. and B.A. Meanwhile, many graduated students have gone outside the district to pursue master's degree.

Suryodaya Municipality Mayor Ran Bahadur Rai said, "Only through education various types of discrimination seen in society be eradicated, for which the role of women is crucial." He said that educating women was essential not only for the development of the municipality but also for the nation as a whole.

Navin Raj Poudel, the technical assistant of the Education, Youth, and Sports Department of Suryodaya Municipality said that it costs around Rs. 100,000 for each student to complete a four-year bachelor's course. He said that the municipality had already spent Rs. 20 million for the 'Daughters and Daughters-in-Law Educational Programme'.

Among the students enrolled in the scholarship programme, 27 have have discontinued their studies. Milan Bhattarai, the chief administrative officer of the municipality, informed that the municipality had increased the amount spent on the educational programme by an additional Rs. 3 million. He said, "Money spent by the municipality would not be result-oriented unless women are enthusiastic to pursue their education."

According to Campus Chief Kattel, many women drop out due to marriage and moving elsewhere. He said that the municipality had initiated for the educational programme so that no one would be deprived of education due to lack of funds. He said, "This programme has enabled women from disadvantaged families to get quality education."

Pratika Pradhan, a student who benefitted from daughter and daughter-in-law's education programme, said that she was able to graduate only because of the scholarship.

Lalita Nepal, a member of the campus operating committee, said that the education programme had proven to be a boon, especially for women from disadvantaged families.

CM Shah pledges to implement RTI

RSS
Sudurpaschim, Feb. 10

Sudurpaschim Province's Chief Minister Kamal Bahadur Shah asserted that he was committed to implementing citizen's right to information (RTI).

At an orientation programme organized in Kailali on Friday, CM Shah clarified that the provincial government was ready to create enabling environment for effective implementation f the RTI. "We will not be able to reach anywhere if there is no accountability and transparency. The issue of RTI is important towards this."

National Information Commission's Chief Commissioner Mahendra Man Gurung viewed that the meaningful participation of citizens was needed for use and practice of the RTI to ensure good-governance and economic prosperity.

Similarly, Chairperson of the National Federation for RTI, Umid Bagchand, shared that the campaign was launched for the welfare of the citizens by effectively implementing RTI.

RTI activist Yadunath Banjara informed that the legal provision stipulates that every public agency should automatically publish its activities every three months and provide information to the information seekers within 15 days of application. On the occasion, Secretary at the Province's Ministry for Internal Affairs and Law, Sushil Vaidya, journalists Dirgharaj Upadhyay and Chitranga Thapa shed light on the current state of the RTI in Nepal.

The orientation saw encouraging participations of working journalists in various districts of Sudurpaschim Province. The RTI is enshrined in constitution as the fundamental rights of the citizens. However, many public agencies are still lax to provide information about their activities.

It was shared that in 16 years span, National Information Commission had to take action against over 36 information officers and chief of the offices from various public bodies reluctant to provide information.

Patients flow rises by 23% in Narayani Hospital

RSS
Parsa, Feb. 10

The Birgunj-based Narayani Hospital has witnessed significant rise in patients' flow since the hospital launched specialized services. The number of patients visiting the hospital has soared up by 23 percent after the Hospital started offering modern healthcare services, such as MRI, CitiScan, dialysis, endoscopy and echocardiogram (eco) among others at a reasonable price, according to the Hospital.

A total of 110,326 patients were recorded within six months last fiscal year, while during the same period this fiscal year, 135,702 patients visited the Hospital, an increase by 24,276, according to Dr Uday Narayan Singh, Information Officer at the Narayani Hospital.

Dr Singh viewed that the increasing number of patients visiting the Hospital could be attributed to the growing trust of people in doctors and hospital services. The Hospital also attracts patients from bordering Indian cities, Dr Singh added. The services provided here are 40 per cent cheaper than other hospitals in the locality.

Worries for final resting place for oneself

BY KABIRAJ GHIMIRE
Hile, Feb. 10

Man Prasad Iwahang, 82, of Mangdangwa village of Sangurigadhi Rural Municipality-2 has constructed a final resting place for himself. He wished for the construction of a concrete house in his desired place as his final resting place, after his demise. The practice of building one's final resting place is on the rise in the Limbu community.

The locals call such mortuary Kapurthan in their local language. In the Limbu language, it is called 'Chehim'. 'Che' means corpse and 'him' means house.

Iwahang has five children, four daughters and a son but he lives with his 73-year-old wife Shukharani Iwahang. He has built a two-roomed Kapurthan for himself and his wife.

Five years ago, he constructed Kapurthan investing Rs. 100,000. The bodies of the Iwahang couple will be placed in the Kapurthan, after their demise.

"Although all my children are abroad, I want my village to be my final resting place. They might fail to return on time to perform our funeral rites, but I believe that my beloved villagers will place us in the constructed final resting place," said Iwahang.

Nain Kumar Tumpapo of the same place also built an attractive two-roomed Kapurthan a few years ago for himself and his wife.

Generally, after the death of a person of the Limbu caste, it is customary to build a mortuary house or Kapurthan at the place where the body is cremated. But in Budhimorang of Sangurigadhi Rural Municipality of Dhankuta Ward No. 2, the practice of making graves in a chosen destination before their demise is on the rise. Even now, 15 elderly people of Mangdangwa village have built Kapurthan in their chosen place and as per their design.

According to local social worker Ramesh Iwahang, this tradition started around 1983. Subwa Chandra Prasad Tumpapo started this tradition for the first time. After the death of his wife in 1982, he built Kapurthan for himself in 1983.

He passed away in 2000 after 17 years of building Kaputhan. When he built it for the first time, people found it strange. Many people came to see the house. Many people started calling him Chihan Budha (the old man of the grave). Now this custom is not new in this place, many people started constructing their final resting place before their demise, said Ramesh Iwahang.

According to the Mundhum scripture, it is customary to bury them in the soil after death, but people prefer constructing their final resting place before death as per their wish and nowhere in the scriptures it is written that they should construct their final resting place.

Chinese New Year Day marked in Lumbini

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10



PHOTO: TRN

Participants extending their New Year wishes on the occasion of Chinese New Year.

Speakers at an interaction pointed out Nepal might gain from serving as a bridge for dialogue between its two largest neighbours, China and India. The speakers were speaking at an event celebrating Chinese New Year Day, which was marked in Lumbini on Saturday.

At the interaction organised by the Nepal-China Friendship Society Lumbini in Bhairahawa, Lumbini Buddhist University Vice-Chancellor Subarna Lal Bajracharya stated that Nepal may benefit greatly from serving as a bridge for talks between the two neighbouring countries, according to a statement issued by Nepal China Friendship Society, Lumbini.

Vice Chancellor Bajracharya stated that Nepal had the opportunity to reconcile two neighbours with the world's most powerful economy and vast populations by maintaining balanced relations.

"It is well known to everyone that there is an undeclared bitterness between China and India; Nepal can act as a bridge to reconcile it," Bajracharya said. "Nepal can become a bridge between China and India if it demonstrates the ability to gain the trust of both countries. If it succeeds in its efforts, Nepal's economic progress and prosperity will not be far off."

Nepal is China's southern gate, and we have not made effective use of it. Because the Chinese do not have easy admission into India but do have easy entry into Nepal, Nepal requested that the government keep this door open at all times, Bajracharya noted.

It is possible to invest in agriculture and tourism in collaboration with China, he stated, adding that China has provided Rs. 500 million in grants for the construction of the Lumbini Buddhist University building in Devdaha, with the goal of teaching 4,000 Nepalese and 16,000 Chinese students.

Dr. Sagar Neupane, a specialist on Chinese affairs, stated that China was willing to assist Nepal in a variety of areas, but Nepal has failed to accept support by gaining China's trust. He proposed steps to raise the scholarship quota in China.

Professor Kumar Khadka stated that because China has millions of Buddhist followers, inviting them to Lumbini should be a top priority. He suggested that the government take real efforts to allow the Chinese planes to fly into Bhairahawa and Pokhara airports.

Khadka requested the government to enact a plan to attract Chinese investment, cutting-edge industrial and agricultural technology of China at an upcoming investment conclave in Nepal.

Narayan Prasad Sapkota, chairperson of the Nepal China Friendship Society, Lumbini stressed the importance of implementing the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) project in Nepal to develop and broaden the relationship with China.

He stated that everyone should play a role in bringing Chinese Buddhist pilgrims to Lumbini, ensuring that Lumbini and Buddhism remain a priority in relations with China.

On the Chinese New Year's Day, Sapkota also expressed his best wishes to the Chinese people and thanked the Chinese Ambassador to Nepal for his greetings to Nepalis.

Chinese New Year is known as 'Chun Chye' or 'Spring Festival'. The Chinese New Year is traditionally celebrated in mid-January or the second week of February. The Chinese Dragon Year has begun from February 10, this year.

Nepalgunj-Janakpur flight on progress for the pilgrims



PHOTO: SIRAJ KHAN/TRN

Officials in a meeting about conducting Nepalgunj-Janakpur air flight service to cater to the needs of pilgrims from western Nepal to Janaki Temple in Janakpur.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Feb. 10

An initiation has been launched to conduct Nepalgunj-Janakpur air flight service to cater to the needs of pilgrims and other passengers from western Nepal to visit the Janaki Temple in Janakpur and from Janakpur to visit the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, India through Nepalgunj.

Coordinator of Tourism Promotion Forum Banke, Krishna Prasad Shrestha, said that the meeting held under the chairmanship of Prashant Bista, the head of Nepalgunj sub-metropolitan city, in the presence of tourism businesspersons and other stakeholders of the region, decided to request the airlines companies of Nepal for Nepalgunj-Janakpur flight.

He said that if the Nepalgunj-Janakpur air flight can be started, a large number of religious tourists from Eastern Nepal along with Indian religious tourists in Nepalgunj would benefit, which will eventually help in the economic development of both cities.

President of the Nepal Association of Tour and Travel Agents (NATTA) Banke, Sriram Sigdel, said that the Nepalgunj-Janakpur air flight has been planned for a long time and now with the construction of Ram Temple in Ayodhya, the need for it has further increased.

He said that this flight will connect the western Tarai with the east Tarai and it will also attract Indian tourists in Nepal. According to him, this initiative will create new destinations for religious tourism.

Meanwhile, the meeting also discussed holding a tourism mart in Nepalgunj. Preparations are being made to organise a travel mart in Nepalgunj in the coming March.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport
Department of Roads
Mechanical Training Center, Patandhoka

Invitation for Bids

Date of publication: 2024/02/11

The Mechanical Training Centre, Patandhoka, Lalitpur invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the following construction works and procurement of goods through National Competitive Bidding – Single Stage Single Envelope Bidding procedures.

Descriptions	IFB No.	Estimated Amount (with VAT) NRs.	Minimum bid security amount, NRs.
Construction of Equipment Parking Garage in Heavy Equipment Division, Itahari	**MTC/337310113/NCB/080-81/03**	Rs. 91,45,934.37	220,000.00
Supply and Delivery of Workshop Tools and Equipments	**MTC/337310113/NCB/080-81/04**	-	3,00,000.00

For more details, please visit PPMO website: www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

My motto is: Contented with little,
yet wishing for more.
- Charles Lamb

EDITORIAL

Unregistered Businesses

Operating an unregistered business is illegal. The owner of the business could face both fine and legal actions, and authorities can shut down those businesses. The registered business adhering to the rules and regulations can enjoy the benefit of limited liability, which protects personal assets from business debts and lawsuits. Likewise, such types of businesses pay taxes to the state and help in revenue generation. Operating a business without registration may help them avoid extra costs and evade tax, but such a bad practice can ultimately land the business people in the soup. They face serious legal and financial risks while the consumers get cheated.

The report of the Nepal Distributive Trade Survey, 2022, conducted by the National Statistics Office (NSO), indicates that approximately 68 per cent of business establishments are registered with government agencies, while the remaining 32 per cent operate without getting properly registered. The survey covered all types of trade activities including motor trade and repair, wholesale and retail trade. The objective of the survey was to measure the contribution of the wholesale and retail trade sector to the national economy as well as finding key indicators such as number of employees, salaries and wage, trade margin and income and expenditure of trade establishments. Informal sector businesses like business on streets are not registered, though such businesses play a huge role in the economy. As these businesses go untaxed, the government does not have a data of how many people are employed in such businesses and how much turnover they make, and how they influence the economy of our country.

The survey findings indicated that Madhes Province has the highest proportion of businesses operating without registration with any government agencies, while Bagmati Province has the largest number of registered businesses. This disparity between provinces may reflect varying levels of awareness about registration requirements, accessibility to government services, enforcement of regulations, and other socio-economic factors influencing business in different regions of Nepal. It's important for policymakers and relevant stakeholders to do deep study of the underlying reasons for these regional differences and to implement strategies to promote registration of businesses, particularly in regions with lower registration rates. This could involve increasing awareness campaigns, streamlining registration processes, providing incentives for registration, and strengthening law enforcement mechanisms to ensure greater adherence to regulatory requirements across all provinces

This finding shows a significant portion of businesses are operating in the informal sector, without adhering to the obligation of formal registration. Unregistered businesses have limited access to resources and business opportunities. Thus, it is essential for policymakers and relevant authorities to address the reasons behind the high rate of running businesses without getting registered and take measures to encourage them to undergo proper registration process, as it benefits them as well as the government. It is also a duty of citizens to abide by the state's law enacted for their own wellbeing. Doing so can help formalise the economy, improve tax compliance, enhance legal protections for businesses and consumers, and foster a more environment conducive for sustainable economic growth and development of the country.

Reduce School Dropouts

SUGAM GAUTAM

Numerous problems are looming in Nepal's educational sector. The mass exodus of graduate students is the most widely discussed phenomenon. Over the years, the enrollment rate in the higher level has gone down alarmingly. The universities have been working on attracting students by introducing various schemes. The government's indifference to improving the quality of education is apparent. Although the budget allocation for education has slightly increased, there's no notable gain.

At present, around 10 per cent of the budget is allocated to education, an uptick compared to the past year. Despite this, news of students not gaining access to textbooks by the end of the academic year circulates now and then, hinting at the shoddy execution of plans. The task of ameliorating the distribution of textbooks is easier said than done. It is beyond one's imagination to discern the difficulties faced by the students who make do without textbooks. In some places, students have to rely on tuins, perilous wire bridges built for crossing the river, to reach school.

School dropout, among others, is a persistent issue that must be addressed seriously. The retention rate keeps decreasing as the level goes up. Numerous factors contribute to the decreasing retention rate. As the majority of people are facing economic hardships, not every child is able to attend school. In contrast to the city areas, the marginalised population from remote areas is deprived of basic-level education, making them vulnerable to many problems throughout their life. Poverty is considered the root cause of school dropout. Parents in rural areas can't afford to spend money on children's education; instead, they seek children's assistance in their work to increase family income.

Poorly managed physical structures, a lack of good teachers, and inadequate textbooks also contribute to the increasing number of school dropouts. If the government had created a healthy teaching environment by providing all required resources, parents would have not stopped sending their wards to schools. The distribution of school uniforms and mid-day meals can bring a shift in people's attitudes. By providing various kinds of training on a regular basis, schools must be able to impart basic skills that might come in handy even if the students couldn't complete their higher education.

The government must instill the notion that education is for all regardless of gender and different socio-economic statuses. Discrimination on any aspect should not surface in schools where people from diverse backgrounds come under the same roof. The public must be made aware of the importance of education, and every single person must realise that education is their basic right.

It is imperative to understand that depriving a child of education is deducing the future resource of the nation. On the societal level, local leaders must encourage every parent to send their children to school. Not only leaders but every educated person must encourage the children to go to schools. By alleviating the problem of school dropout, the government will be able to educate all citizens, thereby by creating a civilised and prosperous society.

TU Education Needs Systemic Reforms



Prof. Bhupa P. Dhamala

We are well aware that numerous media pages are filled with gloomy news that Nepali higher education institutions are depleted of students, especially those universities that are running humanities and social science programmes. One might retort that the student number is increasing in totality but it seems to decrease in an individual college because the number of colleges is growing rapidly with at least one college in each (rural) municipality. Another pretext might be that the colleges that provide quality education are attracting many more students than those that are not. But none of these claims are true.

The student number has indeed been proportionately decreasing in many colleges for several decades. This is a bitter reality that many of us realise but cannot alter the situation with any effort. It is thus too late to retrospect why we cannot do what is expected of us. There is no reason to deny that there are primarily three things that have caused the decline in the number of students and the degeneration of the quality of education. Those things are the intervention of partisan politics, deterrence to meritorious graduates, and the absence of employment opportunities in the country.

Partisan politics

Many people assume that the low quality of education in Nepali universities is due to politics in the university. We cannot disprove this assumption by any evidence. Nor can we claim that this assumption is invalid. But we need to understand that no higher education can be free of politics in the true sense. What do we say, for instance, about the promotion of federal democratic culture as one of the fundamental goals of university education? The problem is not politics as such, but its malpractice is the chief reason for educational degeneration. Political malpractice means power sharing of different political groups in university affairs.

Almost everybody in the country admits that our universities have been the playground of partisan politics. There is the intervention of partisan politics in such spheres as appointment of top university leaders, general administration, and selection of teachers based on party politics, nepotism, and external influence. The current repeated delay in appointing the Vice Chancellor of Tribhuvan University is self-evident to prove that the Chancellorship of a political leader is inappropriate because a political being cannot do politically neutral practice. With due respect to the Prime Minister in state affairs, we need to explicitly say that this is not the Prime Minister's business to search for and appoint the Vice-Chancellor.

Our political system must make legal provisions that the University apex leader cannot be any other person than a proven academician. Further, that academician should be developed through academic practices for several years, but not the involvement in political activities or trade unions of any kind. Despite allegations that the university leaders are purely academicians, they are not what they ought to be, ironically though the aspirants of Tribhuvan University Vice-Chancellorship are declaring themselves to be non-partisan in a situation of partisan political practice. Can anyone believe in their words while the whole university structure is infected with partisan politics?

Most surprisingly, many of them

> As a byproduct of political malpractice, meritorious graduates are discouraged from entering the university services.

have not a track record of non-partisan attitudes and behaviour in the past. It is also quite sure that no one is ready to sacrifice their coveted post for the sake of purely academic practices even as partisan political activities repeatedly intervene the university affairs. The truly honest practice would be they will resign from the position of Vice-Chancellorship if any partisan political intervention occurs in the course of their academic practices.

As part of political malpractice, the non-academic practices of multiple associations of teachers, employees, and students have become hindrances to quality education which is deterring Nepali students from continuing their studies in their home country. It is causing the university structure to decay limb by limb. Consequently, the quality of university education is declining gradually despite denials of politically appointed university leaders. Therefore, unless we establish a purely academic system of appointment of university leaders, the same will be repeated time and again resulting in the utter decay of the academic environment for quality education in higher education institutions.

Deterrence to merit

However, politics is not the chief reason alone for the degeneration of university education. As a byproduct of political malpractice, meritorious graduates are discouraged from entering the university services. The University Service Commission has not been an entirely independent entity that can separate wheat and chaff in the filtering process of appropriate candidates for academic jobs. We have seen in the past that this entity has been dysfunctional either by the non-academic pressure of external forces or by the indolence of the Commission leaders. We have seen that in many cases the genuinely meritorious candidates have failed in the mechanically devised stereotypical examination system whereas the mediocre ones have passed.

Meritorious candidates are thus humiliated by non-professional officials. Paradoxically, meritorious graduates are attracted by foreign universities where they have proven academic excellence in their services. More than anything else, Nepali students are fleeing to foreign countries not merely for quality education but also for job opportunities. Many graduates grumble that they are reluctant to study in Nepali universities because they will not be able to get employment in the job market. This economic reason is probably stronger than the political reason for opting for foreign universities.

In the previous write-up published in this daily, this scribe had advocated for connecting universities with industries, which may have been unnoticed by the responsible officeholders. This is not to claim that those ideas were the only remedies, but what is saddening is that the leaders have no time to bother about what any best academicians say about the university education, let alone an average intellectual like this scribe. It is quite surprising who advises the top political leaders to do what ought not to be done and what inspires them to do something that is not worth doing. Unless we create an environment for employment opportunities within the country, we cannot improve university education.

(The author is the chairman of Molung Foundation. bhupadhamala@gmail.com)

Counterfeit Drugs Threaten Public Health



Dr. Shyam P Lohani

Counterfeit medicine is a growing problem worldwide. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), an estimated 10 per cent of drugs worldwide are counterfeit, with the majority being found in low and middle-income countries. These counterfeit medicines can be found in both developed and developing countries and can have serious consequences for public health. Counterfeit medicine poses a significant threat to public health, particularly in the third world. The production and distribution of fake drugs have reached alarming levels, endangering the lives of millions of people who rely on these medications for their well-being.

Many cases of counterfeit medicine go unreported, and it can be difficult to distinguish between genuine and fake drugs. However, there have been several studies that have shed light on the scope of the problem. A study published in the Lancet Global Health in 2015 estimated that the global market for counterfeit and substandard medicines was worth $75 billion. The study also found that the problem was most prevalent in low- and middle-income countries, where up to 30 per cent of medicines were estimated to be counterfeit or substandard.

Pervasive issue

Another study published in the American Journal of Tropical Medicine and Hygiene in 2018 found that counterfeit antimalarial drugs were a significant problem in sub-Saharan Africa. The study estimated that up to 20 per cent of antimalarial drugs in the region were counterfeit and that this was contributing to the high burden of malaria in the region. Counterfeit medicine is a pervasive issue in the third world, where weak regulatory systems, poverty, and limited access to healthcare make populations vulnerable to the dangers of fake drugs. This alarming statistic highlights the urgent need for concerted efforts to address this crisis.

The use of counterfeit medicine poses severe health risks to individuals. These fake drugs often contain substandard or incorrect ingredients, inadequate dosages, or even toxic substances. As a result, patients may experience adverse reactions, treatment failure, or, in extreme cases, death. In addition, counterfeit medicine undermines public trust in the healthcare system and can have economic consequences. The consequences are particularly dire for vulnerable populations, such as children, pregnant women, and those suffering from chronic illnesses.

The impact of counterfeit medicine extends beyond public health concerns. The proliferation of fake drugs in the third world undermines healthcare systems, erodes public trust in medications, and drains already limited resources. Patients who unknowingly purchase counterfeit drugs may experience prolonged illnesses, leading to increased healthcare costs and reduced productivity. Additionally, the pharmaceutical industry suffers from lost revenue due to counterfeiters profiting from their products. Counterfeit medicine not only poses a threat to patients but also undermines the integrity of the pharmaceutical industry. By

> The proliferation of fake drugs in the third world undermines healthcare systems, erodes public trust in medications, and drains already limited resources.

implementing robust control measures, we can protect the reputation and sustainability of the pharmaceutical industry, ensuring the continued development and availability of life-saving medications.

Several factors contribute to the persistence of counterfeit medicine in the third world. Weak regulatory frameworks, corruption, and inadequate enforcement mechanisms create an environment conducive to the production and distribution of fake drugs. Poverty and limited access to affordable healthcare also drive individuals to seek cheaper alternatives, often falling victim to counterfeit medications. Addressing these root causes requires a multi-faceted approach involving governments, international organisations, and pharmaceutical companies.

Preventing the spread of counterfeit medicine requires a multi-faceted approach. This includes strengthening regulatory systems, improving supply chain management, and increasing public awareness. Controlling counterfeit medicine necessitates the strengthening of regulatory systems at both national and international levels. This includes enhancing surveillance, improving supply chain management, and implementing stricter penalties for counterfeiters. By prioritising the control of counterfeit medicine, governments can demonstrate their commitment to public health and safety, while also fostering international cooperation to combat this global issue.

Collaboration

Collaboration between governments, international organisations, and pharmaceutical companies is crucial to ensure the production, distribution, and sale of safe and genuine medications. Additionally, investing in healthcare infrastructure, training healthcare professionals, and promoting access to affordable medicines can help reduce the demand for counterfeit drugs. The production and distribution of counterfeit medicine are often linked to organised criminal networks. These criminals exploit the vulnerability of patients and the profitability of the pharmaceutical industry, generating substantial illicit profits. By controlling counterfeit medicine, we can disrupt these criminal networks, safeguarding public health and undermining their financial incentives.

The problem of counterfeit medicine in the third world is a grave concern that demands immediate attention. The lives of millions of people are at stake, and the consequences of inaction are dire. It is imperative to address the root causes, implement effective strategies, and protect vulnerable populations from the dangers of counterfeit medicine. Only through collective efforts can we ensure a safer and healthier future for all. Thus, in conclusion, the importance of controlling counterfeit medicine cannot be overstated. It is a matter of life and death, with far-reaching implications for public health, patient safety, and the pharmaceutical industry.

(Dr. Shyam P Lohani is the executive director at Health Concern. Lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 11, 1974

Fruit Saplings To Farmers

Doti, Feb. 10: The agricultural development office has made available 2000 various fruit saplings to local farmers at fair prices, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

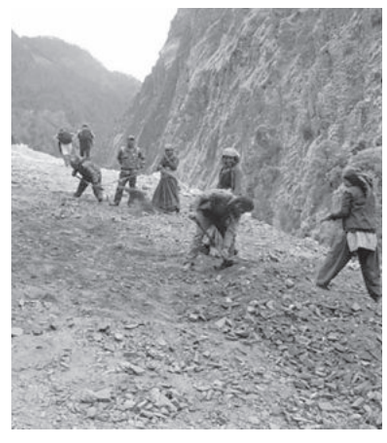
End Gender Disparity In Workplaces

The news story you ran about the growing women's participation in labour force titled *"Women's participation increases in daily wage work"* suggests that a profound shift is taking root in Nepal, and this bodes well for our many other sectors, including economy.

With the provision of equal daily wages for both genders working in the construction sector in Humla district, the involvement of women in the sector has shot up, making them feel empowered and financially independent.

This means gender disparity in workplaces have kept our women from joining the workforce. For a country to advance socially, economically, politically, and to create a just society, it cannot afford to keep its women confined to household chores. This is also essential to increase productivity, raise GDP, and eventually bring prosperity.

There is a mounting evidence that ending unjust gender pay gap prods



many women to contribute economically. Imagine what we can achieve once we end all other forms of discrimination against women!

Nikeesa Neupane
Dang

TAILPIECE

A lawyer died and arrived at the Pearly Gates.

Saint Peter asked him, "What have you done to merit entrance into Heaven?"

The lawyer thought a moment, then said, "A week ago, I gave a quarter to a homeless person on the street."

Saint Peter asked Gabriel to check this out in the records, and after a moment Gabriel affirmed that it was true.

Saint Peter said, "Well, that's fine, but it's not really quite enough to get you into Heaven."

The Lawyer said, "Wait, wait! There's more! Three years ago, I also gave a homeless person a quarter."

Saint Peter nodded to Gabriel, who, after a moment, nodded back to affirm that it was true.

Saint Peter then whispered to Gabriel, "Well, what do you suggest we do with this fellow?"

Gabriel gave the lawyer a sidelong glance, then said to Saint Peter, "Let's give him back his 50 cents and tell him to go to Hell."

Ukraine's new army chief signals new momentum

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Feb. 10

Ukraine's new military chief signalled Friday that he wants to build new momentum, saying his immediate goals are to improve troop rotation at the front lines and harness the power of new technology, at a time when Kyiv's forces are largely on the defensive in the war with Russia.

Col. Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyi, who previously was the commander of Ukraine's ground forces, spoke a day after President Volodymyr Zelenskyy put him in charge of the battlefield campaign with the war poised to enter its third year. He replaced the broadly popular Gen. Valerii Zaluzhnyi.

"New tasks are on the agenda," Syrskyi said on his Telegram channel.

Syrskyi emphasized the need for "maintaining a balance between the fulfillment of combat tasks and the restoration of units with the intensification of training," in an apparent reference to the need to rotate troops exhausted by nearly two years of fighting.

He also stressed the importance of "new technical solutions and the scaling of successful experience, such as the use of unmanned systems and modern electronic warfare means."

Though he provided little detail, his remarks appeared to align with Zelenskyy's stated aim of bringing "renewal" to the armed forces and adopting a fresh approach to the fight.

Later on Friday, Zelenskyy announced that he also replaced the chief of the military's General Staff, Lt. Gen. Serhiy Shaptala with Maj. Gen. Anatoliy Barhylyevych, whose experience and understanding of "the tasks of this war and Ukrainian goals" he noted. Shaptala was a close associate of Zaluzhnyi.

But the changes at the top won't solve some of Ukraine's biggest problems: a shortage of manpower that has helped sap morale and may require a mass mobilization, and the inadequate supply of Western weapons to take on Russia's might.



PHOTO: AP

People hold a Ukrainian national flag during a protest a day after the resignation of General Valerii Zaluzhnyi at Independence Square in Kyiv, Ukraine, Friday, Feb. 9, 2024.

Kyiv officials are "rethinking" their war strategy "with a new emphasis on improved technology and updated command and control," said James Nixey, an analyst at London's Chatham House think tank.

One sign of that may be the claimed recent sinking of a Russian warship in the Black Sea by a new generation of Ukrainian naval drones.

"It's not going to be easy" for Syrskyi, said Marina Miron, a researcher at the War Studies Department of King's College London. "There are a lot of problems" for Ukraine at the moment.

She cited a lack of ammunition, uncertainty about new weapons from Ukraine's Western allies, a manpower shortage, people's reluctance to be drafted, the tiredness of troops getting no respite from the front lines, and the question of how Zaluzhnyi's departure might affect morale.

Whereas Zaluzhnyi was a proponent at this stage of the war of active defense — securing defensive lines while also searching for Russia's weak points and hitting rear areas with long-range strikes — Syrskyi "will try to push the Ukrainian forces. ... He will try to increase counterattacks possibly," Miron said in a telephone interview.

That would align with Zelenskyy's desire to take a more aggressive approach.

The Associated Press spoke to soldiers and commanders on the front lines, who expressed varied views about the changes at the top. Some said they would reserve judgement on Syrskyi until they witness changes on the ground, while others said he was a competent and capable general.

The shake-up caused some apprehension on the streets of the capital, Kyiv.

Alisa Riazantseva, a 35-year-old marketing specialist, said she had been "generally satisfied" with Zaluzhnyi. "We hope that our government has not made a big mistake" by replacing him, she told the AP.

Oleksandr Azimov, 61, said there was "some discontent, some dissatisfaction" about the changes at the top .

The consternation appeared to be rooted in previous criticism of Syrskyi's strategy of holding on for nine months to the city of Bakhmut, which brought the war's longest and bloodiest battle and cost Ukraine dearly in troop losses, but also served to sap Russia's forces.

Later Friday, dozens gathered in Kyiv's Independence Square to protest Zaluzhnyi's removal. They chanted slogans in support of the former army chief and called for the ousters of Syrskyi and Zelenskyy. A soldier tried to reason with the protesters, telling them the government has a plan, but they were having none of it.

With the fighting about to enter its third year, Kyiv is largely dependent on support from Western countries where signs of war fatigue have emerged.

That has left Ukraine on the back foot while Russia has placed its economy on a war footing and is building up its weapon stockpiles.

Analysts detected no sign of a deeper malaise in Zelenskyy's move, which had been rumored for weeks.

"Command changes are normal for a state fighting a war over several years," the Institute for the Study of War, a Washington think tank, said late Thursday.

Asked about Zaluzhnyi's exit and Syrskyi's appointment, Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov on Friday downplayed the reshuffle, saying that they wouldn't affect the course of the Russian operation.

Pakistan hits back at criticism of election conduct



PHOTO: AP

Supporters of Former Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif' party 'Pakistan Muslim League-N' celebrate their party victory in the initial results of the country's parliamentary election, in Lahore, Pakistan, Friday, Feb. 9, 2024.

AP
Islamabad, Feb. 10

Pakistan on Saturday hit back at criticism over the conduct of its parliamentary elections, which were held amid sporadic militant attacks and an unprecedented stoppage of all mobile phone services.

The strongly worded reaction from the Foreign Ministry insisted the vote was peaceful and successful.

The U.S. State Department said that Thursday's vote was held under undue restrictions on freedoms of expression, association and peaceful assembly. The European Union has also said it regrets the lack of a level playing field due to the inability of some political actors to contest the elections.

The ministry said it was surprised by "the negative tone of some of these statements, which neither take into account the complexity of the electoral process, nor acknowledge the free and enthusiastic exercise of the right to vote by tens of millions of Pakistanis".

It said such statements "ignore the undeniable fact that Pakistan has held general elections, peacefully and successfully, while dealing with serious security threats resulting primarily from foreign sponsored terrorism."

It said there was no nationwide internet shutdown and "only mobile services were suspended for the day to avoid terrorist incidents on polling day."

A Commonwealth observer group praised election officials for holding the vote despite multiple attacks, and said it received reports of intimidation and violence against candidates, members of the media and other citizens. Without naming any party, it said it also received reports of arrests and detentions, "especially of supporters and members of a main political party."

In Thursday's vote, no political party gained a simple majority and independent candidates backed by imprisoned former Prime Minister Imran Khan took a lead in the vote count.

It forced Khan's main rival, three-time premier Nawaz Sharif, to announce plans to try to form a coalition government. Khan was disqualified from running because of criminal convictions.

Magnitude 5.7 quake hits Mauna Loa volcano on Hawaii

AP
Honolulu, Feb. 10

A magnitude 5.7 earthquake struck the world's largest active volcano on Friday — Mauna Loa on the Big Island of Hawaii — knocking items off shelves and cutting power in a nearby town but not immediately prompting reports of serious damage.

The earthquake, which didn't cause a tsunami and which the U.S. Geological Survey initially reported as magnitude 6.3, was centered on Mauna Loa's southern flank at a depth of 23 miles (37 kilometers), 1.3 miles (2 kilometres) southwest of Pahala.

"It shook us bad to where it wobbled some knees a little bit," said Derek Nelson, the manager of the Kona Canoe Club restaurant in the oceanside community of Kona, on the island's western side. "It shook all the windows in the village."

There was a power outage affecting about 300 customers in Naalehu that appeared to be related to the earthquake, said Darren Pai, spokesperson for Hawaiian Electric Company.

The earthquake struck after 10 a.m. local time, less than two hours before an unrelated quake with a preliminary magnitude of 4.6 shook Southern California.

Mauna Loa last erupted in late 2022. It's one of five volcanoes that make up the Big Island, which is the southernmost in the Hawaiian archipelago.

Earthquakes can occur in Hawaii for a variety of reasons, including magma moving under the surface. In Friday's case, the Hawaiian Volcano Observatory said the likely cause was the weight of the Hawaiian Islands bending and stressing the Earth's crust and upper mantle.

That's what caused a magnitude 6.9 earthquake that struck off Kiholo Bay on the Big Island's northwest coast in 2006. That temblor damaged roads and buildings and knocked out power as far away as Honolulu, on the island of Oahu, about 200 miles (322 kilometers) to the north.

Helen Janiszewski, an assistant professor in the University of Hawaii at Manoa's Department of Earth Sciences, said the Hawaiian Islands lie on the Pacific oceanic tectonic plate and have some of the world's biggest volcanoes.

"So there's a huge amount of mass of rock associated with the islands and because of that, it's actually enough to slightly displace the Pacific oceanic plate beneath the islands," she said. "And that force causes earthquakes sometimes."

Asia welcomes Lunar New Year of the Dragon with temple visits and celebrations

AP
China, Feb 10

People across Asia welcomed the Lunar New Year on Saturday with family gatherings, festivals and temple visits to ask for blessings.

The Lunar New Year is the most important annual holiday in China, a time for reunions with relatives and friends and to enjoy festive feasts. Each year is named after one of the 12 signs of the Chinese zodiac, with this year being the Year of the Dragon — widely considered the most auspicious zodiac sign in Chinese communities.

The Year of the Dragon is also a popular year to give birth for Chinese because many couples hope their children will possess remarkable qualities symbolized by dragons, including strength, power and success.

Many residents of Hong Kong dressed in red, a lucky colour in Chinese culture, to mark the start of the year. In gatherings, they savoured rice cakes and turnip cakes, with children receiving cash-stuffed red envelopes as blessings from their married relatives. Outdoor exhibitions and floral displays prepared for the festival offered a chance for revellers to pose for photos.



PHOTO: AP

Worshippers pray as they burn their first joss sticks at a temple to welcome in the Lunar New Year of the Dragon in Hong Kong, Friday, Feb. 9, 2024.

In Beijing, crowds of people flocked to temple fairs to see traditional folk performances and bought snacks and artwork from booths. Many lit incense sticks to pray for good health and fortune.

Along with the predominantly Chinese societies in the Greater China region, the festival is also celebrated in South Korea, Vietnam and in overseas Chinese communities. In Myanmar and Malaysia, worshippers visited temples to pray for good luck and blessings. In Dharamshala, India, exiled Tibetan monks also took part in ceremonies to mark their new year.

PRISM

Largest balloon dragon assembled

Hong Kong: A dragon sculpture made from approximately 38,000 balloons at a Hong Kong shopping mall was awarded a Guinness World Record.

Balloon artists Sze Tai "Wilson" Pang and Kun Lung Ho led more than 60 volunteers in constructing the sculpture.

The finished dragon measured 137.04 feet long, earning the Guinness World Record for the largest balloon sculpture of a dragon.

The sculpture was created as part of Chinese New Year celebrations and will remain in place until the end of February.

The artists said the biggest challenge was to make sure the dragon remained in one piece without any kind of non-balloon support structure.

Bear tries to enter a home through doggie door

Washington: A Washington woman's home security camera was recording when a large bear attempted to enter her home through the doggie door.

Amy Holt said her camera recorded as the bear approached the back door of her North Bend home.

"The video is completely entertaining, but also makes me a little worried about waking up in bed with the bear next to me," Holt told KOMO-TV.

The video shows the bear attempt to squeeze through the doggie door, which turned out to be too small.

Holt said the bear also tried to unsuccessfully push its way in through her windows.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1826 – University College London is founded as University of London.
1861 – American Civil War: The United States House of Representatives unanimously passes a resolution guaranteeing noninterference with slavery in any state.
1929 – The Kingdom of Italy and the Vatican sign the Lateran Treaty.
1979 – The Iranian Revolution establishes an Islamic theocracy under the leadership of Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini
1990 – Nelson Mandela is released from Victor Verster Prison outside Cape Town, South Africa after 27 years as a political prisoner.
2014 – A military transport plane crashes in a mountainous area of Oum El Bouaghi Province in eastern Algeria, killing 77 people.
2020 – COVID-19 pandemic: The World Health Organization officially names the coronavirus outbreak as COVID-19, with the virus being designated SARS-CoV-2.

Women and minority candidates face challenges in Indonesia polls

AP
Jakarta, Indonesia, Feb. 10

With a broad smile on his face, Jakarta city council candidate Rian Ernest answers almost every question about his faith with the same line.

"I'm Christian, but my wife and children are Muslims, so pray for me to get the guidance," Ernest said.

Ernest is one of thousands of candidates facing the contradictions of seeking office as a member of a minority in the world's third-largest democracy, which is holding national elections on Wednesday.

Elections in the country often reveal a tension between pluralism and the power of conservatives from its Muslim majority.

Nearly 90% of Indonesia's 277 million people are Muslims. There are just under a million Christians in Jakarta, out of around 10 million people.

Christians like Ernest hold around 14% of seats in the national legislature, while making up just under 9% of the general population, but they face constant questions about their faith. A national quota system has helped more women win office, but fallen short of its own targets. And in this election, a new party is seeking to win representation for marginalized groups like domestic workers and people with disabilities.



PHOTO: AP

Yuni Sri Rahayu, a domestic worker who's running for the Jakarta legislature with the new Labour Party, works at her employers' apartment in Jakarta, Indonesia, on Feb. 6, 2024.

Ernest, a lawyer turned politician, is running for a seat in the city legislature in East Jakarta for Golkar, Indonesia's second largest party. The capital is one of the best places to run as a Christian, he says.

Jakarta elected an ethnic Chinese Christian governor in 2014, but he lost re-election after conservative Muslims accused him of blasphemy, and wound up jailed for it.

After Basuki Tjahaja Purnama accused rivals of misinterpreting the Quran to oppose a Christian governor, hundreds of thousands of people took to the streets in protests. Now Anies Baswedan, who rode the protests to victory over Purnama in the 2017 governor's race, is a leading candidate for president.

"It's the kind of mindset that might make some non-Muslim candidates think twice about campaigning in a conservative Muslim community," Ernest said. He added that most Indonesians are tolerant unless something triggers a conflict, and the country has a pluralist society that respects freedom of expression.

This year, Ernest is trying to win over voters by offering rice for around half the usual price, with a picture of Ernest, his candidate number and a campaign message in each one. He says it's a better alternative to vote buying, which is widespread in Indonesian elections.

Supriatna, a 22-year-old food vendor and first-time voter, said he appreciated the campaign stop in a neighbourhood almost never visited by politicians. He said Ernest's faith does not concern him.

"The most important thing is that legislative candidates want to go directly to the grassroots, asking directly what the people need," said Supriatna, a first-time voter who, like many Indonesians, uses only one name.

Female candidates face perhaps a steeper uphill battle, despite a quota system requiring 30% of candidates to be women since 2004.

Since 2004, the number of seats held by women in the national parliament has climbed from around 8% to just over 21%, according to World Bank figures. Women are even rarer in provincial and district legislatures, only 18% and 15% respectively, according to the General Election Commission. In 25 of Indonesia's 167 district parliaments, no women at all were elected in 2019.

"I want to be there to voice the needs and issues of women that must be accommodated by law," said Muharyati, another candidate in East Jakarta, who goes by only one name.

A 54-year-old single parent of two whose left hand is partially missing, Muharyati chairs the Indonesian Association of Disabled Women and says she had to endure ridicule because of doubts about her competence to sit in Jakarta's House of Representatives.

She is running with the newly formed Labour Party, which is putting forward candidates from marginalized groups in its races across the country.

Muharyati said many policies, laws and regulations tend not to side with women, especially women with disabilities.

"I will fight for equal rights for women and people with disabilities if I am elected to office," Muharyati said.



PHOTO: RSS

Visitors enjoy boating on Indrasarobar lake (Kulekhani reservoir) in Markhu of Makawanpur district on Saturday.

'New budget will focus on infrastructure, education, employment'

RSS
Nuwakot, Feb. 10

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the upcoming fiscal year's budget will focus on infrastructure development, skills generating education and employment creation.

Addressing a Lhosar cultural programme organised by the Tamang community at Tarakeshwor in Nuwakot district on Saturday, the Finance Minister said that the budget would give more emphasis on employment generation by boosting people's income sources.

"Development could not take a pace for long in the past due to political uncertainties. Now, the target will be to make economy robust from development of infrastructure and employment creation through vocational and skills generating education if the resources and means permitted," according to the Finance Minister.

He also expressed the confidence that development will take a speed as political stability was maintained in the country.

On the occasion, Finance Minister Mahat reiterated that the federal government has prioritized the development of Galchhi-Rasuwagadhi road and Tokha-Chhahare tunnel route.

FULFILL CITIZENS' EXPECTATIONS: LEADER KHANAL

RSS
Kaski, Feb. 10

CPN (Unified Socialist) leader Jhalanath Khanal said the government should fulfill citizen's expectations.

At a press meet organised by the Socialist Press Organisation Kaski chapter in Pokhara today, leader Khanal, who is also the former prime minister, said that there was growing dissatisfaction and anger among citizen due to political apathy to their expectation. Stating that the citizens were feeling 'directionless' at present, the former Prime Minister reminded, urging the government to address basic problems facing the citizens.

He argued that the monarchists and revivalists forces were becoming more powerful lately because the government failed to deliver properly. He, thus, viewed that those in power should consider amendment in their policies and programmes.

According to him, there is division and difference in the communist movement in the country due to wrong ideological and political work direction.

31 Palestinians killed in Israeli strikes in Rafah

AP
Rafah, Feb. 10

Israeli airstrikes killed at least 31 Palestinians in Rafah early Saturday, hours after Israel's prime minister said he asked the military to plan for the evacuation of hundreds of thousands of people from the southern Gaza city ahead of a ground invasion.

Benjamin Netanyahu did not provide details or a timeline, but the announcement set off widespread panic. More than half of Gaza's 2.3 million people are packed into Rafah, many after being uprooted repeatedly by Israeli evacuation orders that now cover two-thirds of Gaza's territory. It's not clear where they could run next.

Word of the invasion plans capped a week of increasingly public friction between Netanyahu and the Biden administration. U.S. officials have said an invasion of Rafah without a plan for the civilian population would lead to disaster.

Israel has carried out airstrikes in Rafah almost daily, even after telling civilians in recent weeks to seek shelter there from ground combat in the city of Khan Younis, just to the north.

Overnight into Saturday, three airstrikes on homes in the Rafah area killed 28 people, according to a health official and Associated Press journalists who saw the bodies arriving at hospitals. Each strike killed multiple members of three families, including a total of 10 children, the youngest 3 months old.

Fadel al-Ghannam lost his son, daughter-in-law and four grandchildren in one of the strikes. Standing amid the rubble, he said the strike tore the bodies of his loved ones to shreds.

He feared even worse, with the looming ground invasion of Rafah, and said the world's silence has enabled Israel to proceed. "To this day, the world has not been fair to us and given us our rights," he said.

Later Saturday, another strike killed three senior officers in the civil police, according to Rafah city officials.

In Khan Younis, the focus of the current ground combat, Israeli forces opened fire at Nasser Hospital, the area's largest, killing at least two people and wounding five, according to the medical charity Doctors Without Borders.

Health Ministry spokesman Ashraf al-Qidra said medical staff are no longer able to move between the facility's buildings because of the intense fire. He said 300 medical personnel, 450 patients and 10,000 displaced people are sheltering in the hospital.

The Israeli military had no immediate comment.

The steadily climbing Palestinian death toll — now over 28,000 after four months of war, according to Gaza health officials — has contributed to the friction between Netanyahu and Washington.

Israel holds Hamas responsible for civilian deaths because it fights from within civilian areas, but U.S. officials have pushed back, calling for more surgical strikes. President Joe Biden said this week Israel's response is "over the top."

Israel says that Rafah, which borders Egypt, is the last remaining Hamas stronghold in Gaza after more than four months of war.

"It is impossible to achieve the goal of the war of eliminating Hamas by leaving four Hamas battalions in Rafah," Netanyahu's office said Friday. "On the contrary, it is clear that intense activity in Rafah requires that civilians evacuate the areas of combat."

It said he had ordered the military and security officials to come up with a "combined plan" that included both a mass evacuation of civilians and the destruction of Hamas' forces in the town.

EU reaches agreement on spending rules

AFP
Brussels, Feb. 10

The European Parliament and member states reached an agreement early Saturday on reforms to EU budgetary rules aimed at boosting investment while keeping spending under control.

The text modernises the current rules, known as the Stability and Growth Pact, created in the late 1990s, which limit countries' debt to 60 percent of gross domestic product and public deficits to three percent.

"Deal!," the Belgian Presidency of the Council of the EU said on social media platform X after 16 hours of talks.

The European Union spent two years making an intensive effort to develop reforms supported by the more frugal member states like Germany and other countries, such as France and Italy, which seek more flexibility. After much wrangling between Berlin and Paris, the 27 member states struck a deal in December, then began talks with negotiators from the European Parliament.

The text was criticised for its great complexity and derided by left-wing officials as a tool for imposing austerity on Europe. The negotiators finally reached an agreement early Saturday, in time for the text to be voted on in Strasbourg this spring before the parliamentary break ahead of European elections. The reforms will be formally adopted after agreement between lawmakers and states.

The agreement will allow member states to apply the new rules to their 2025 budgets. "The new rules will help achieve balanced & sustainable public finances, structural reforms, foster investments, growth & jobs creation in the EU," the Belgian presidency said.

The former budgetary framework was considered too drastic and was never really respected. The rules had, however, been suspended since the coronavirus pandemic to give member states wiggle room to spend more during a period of great economic upheaval. During the initial debates between countries, the battle was fierce over how much those old limits should be relaxed to give more room for investment.

With war raging in Europe and the EU making a green transition push, states led by France argued for allowing more space to finance these key areas, including, for example, supplying critical arms to Ukraine.

While confirming the previous limits on debt and budget deficits, the new agreement allows more flexibility in the event of excessive deficits. The text provides looser fiscal rules more adapted to the particular situation of each state, allowing big spenders a slower route back to frugality.

The tailor-made approach means each country presents their own adjustment trajectory to ensure their debt's sustainability, giving them more time if they undertake reforms and investments and allowing a less painful return to fiscal health.

Monitoring would focus on expenditure trends, an economic indicator considered more relevant than deficits, which can fluctuate depending on the level of growth. But Germany and its "frugal" allies managed to tighten this budgetary framework by imposing a quantifiable minimum effort to reduce debt and deficits for all EU countries, despite the reluctance of France and Italy.

FM Saud...

Earlier on Friday, he also met with Eileen Laubacher, Special Assistant to the President and Senior Director for South Asia, National Security Council of the United States of America and discussed matters of mutual interests.

In the morning on Saturday, Komura Masahiro, Parliamentary Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs of Japan held a courtesy meeting with FM Saud and discussed multiple aspects of Nepal-Japan relations.

Likewise, Indra Mani Pandey, Secretary General of BIMSTEC also had a courtesy meeting with him in the margins of the Conference during which Pandey gave an overview of the status of cooperation in various areas under the BIMSTEC.

While in Perth, Minister Saud interacted with the Nepali community focusing on ensuring their welfare in Australia. Minister Saud also stressed the need for collaborating with the Nepali community residing in Australia for the economic benefit of the country.

Make good...

So, it is imperative to develop national economy," Minister Sharma underlined.

Moreover, she argued that development in agriculture, tourism, hydropower and IT could pave way for country's economic prosperity. So, we had no option but to increase production in these sectors and ensure dividend to people.

"Dalal punjibad (crony capitalism) has the notion to extract State/public property, exploit people and incur individual profit. But, against this, collective investment and benefit sharing for national capital formation can pave foundation for socialist economy. We have to be clear on it," Sharma explained.

Moreover, time has come for augmenting investment for national capital formation and self-reliant economy. For it, government is committed, the Minister underlined.

Generating 28,500 MW by 2035...

Study on the 10,800 MW Karnali Chisapani hydropower project, which is a project of strategic importance, has also started.

Sandip Kumar Dev, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, said that the private sector and the government could produce more than 28,500 MW of electricity in the next 12 years.

He said that in the last one and a half years, an environment has been created to produce more than 1,000 megawatts of electricity, and in the next 12 years, we are progressing according to the target of producing more than 28,500 megawatts.

The government has started advancing the hydropower projects as a bilateral venture basis. Under this, Nepal government and Bangladesh government have expressed their commitment to developing the 683 MW Sunkoshi 3 Semi-Reservoir Project, he said.

Policy reforms essential

Due to various reasons, the construction work gets delayed which increases the cost of the project and this is what has discouraged the private sector from investing in the hydropower projects.

The government should pay attention to promptly solve the problems like felling trees in the project sites during the development of a hydro project and transmission lines to realise the ambitious target to generate 28,500 MW electricity and export to India, said Ganesh Karki President of Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN).

He also suggested declaring the next decade as the energy decade to meet the target.

Karki said that the government should create a conducive environment by formulating necessary acts and regulations and making amendments to the existing policies to attract both the domestic and international investors to invest in hydropower before upcoming investment summit slated for April.

Stating that there was a compulsion to visit dozens of ministries and other government bodies to develop a hydropower while local levels are also there to create problems, he suggested managing a one door system to complete all procedures to construct hydropower.

Joint Secretary Dev said that the government has also been facilitating issues related to land acquisition and the forest sector to expedite the project construction works.

The government has prepared a draft of the new Electricity Bill and the draft of the Bill has already been registered in the Parliament.

After the new Electricity Act is introduced, the private sector will be able to participate in the electricity trading, he said.

Private sector to generate 10,000 MW in a decade

IPPAN President Karki said that the long-term electricity trade agreement allowing to export 10,000 megawatts of electricity to India every day in the next 10 years is a historic and welcome move.

Since 1971, electricity has been exchanged between Nepal and India, and a Power Trade Agreement (PTA) was signed in 2014. Based on the same agreement, up to 600 megawatts of electricity was being exported to India for a short period of time for the last two years.

He claimed that the private sector of Nepal alone could generate 10,000 megawatts of electricity in 10 years.

However, to make it possible the government should adopt the policy that the banks and financial institutions should increase their investment in hydropower with due priority.

Likewise, the Power Purchase Agreement (PPA) which is currently being held by the Nepal Electricity Authority should be fully opened and licenses should be given to the private sector for electricity export, he said.

He said that the banks and financial institutions should increase investment in energy, and the government should announce more concessions for energy production.

He said, "It is impossible to export electricity without the involvement of the private sector and the private sector is ready to cooperate with the government."

The capacity of domestic private sector, in terms of investment has increased and started constructing up to 300 MW project at present, he said.

Financing challenges

"There is demand for electricity in home and abroad and we, Nepal, have resources. So, if we are able to manage financing to develop hydropower from domestic and foreign investments, it will be possible to generate the electricity," former secretary Sharma said.

It is estimated that by 2035, about 47 billion US dollar will be required for power generation, transmission and distribution lines. Out of the said investment, about US dollar 24 billion is proposed to be collected from domestic investment and about US dollar 23 billion from foreign direct investment.

Stating that such huge amount of resources cannot be managed by government and private sector of the country alone, he said that the government should create conducive environment for foreign investors to invest in Nepal by facilitating in FDI inflows.

"Proper financial management, environment management and market management are equally important to accelerate hydropower production and the government needs to pay attention to these issues," he said.

Talking about the investment, Thike said that the government should mobilise remittance inflows in the hydropower along with the foreign direct investment as the local resources will not be adequate to generate the targeted power and build the distribution and transmission lines.

Boosting domestic consumption

The government needs to give priority to increasing the consumption of domestically generated electricity. To maximise the use of domestically produced electricity, the government has recently approved an energy consumption enhancement working plan, said Joint Secretary Dev.

At present, hydropower energy accounts only for about 8 per cent of Nepal's total energy demand. Nepal has a great chance to substitute the energy generated from fossil fuels used in transportation, irrigation and household sectors by hydropower energy, he said.

"Transport electrification strategies provide multi-fold benefits. The use of electric vehicles reduces the demand for petroleum products, hence reducing Nepal's reliance on imported energy resources. The use of electric vehicles has increased significantly, which could increase consumption of power," he said.

Organisations such as the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, Nepal Electricity Authority and Alternative Energy Promotion Centre are playing a role in increasing energy consumption, and with the joint efforts of these agencies, the demand for electricity in transportation, irrigation and industrial and business sectors and household activities could be increased tremendously.

Nepal Electricity Authority has already been promoting the use of electric vehicles and working for the construction of transmission and distribution lines for increasing consumption, said Thike.

"We have projected to increase electricity consumption to 13,500 MW in 2035. The NEA is working to increase electricity consumption by promoting the use of electric vehicles, increase additional load to the industries and use of electric stoves," he said.

When per capita electricity consumption reaches 1,500 kWh by 2030 from existing 380, the target of domestic consumption of 13,500 MW electricity will be met, he said.

Expedite transmission/distribution lines

Demanding unnecessary compensation has been a big problem in transmission lines expansion.

Thike said, "No problem is in generation. But, there are many challenges for the completion of transmission lines. However, the NEA is fully dedicated for the generation, transmission and distribution lines and increase domestic consumption and export surplus electricity."

For electricity trade, Nepal and India have recently agreed on eight various topics to facilitate the exchange of electricity by enhancing the capacity of cross-border transmission lines between the two countries.

The 132 kV Kushaha-Kataiya Third Circuit, Raxaul-Parwanipur Second Circuit and Mainhia-Sampatia transmission lines connecting Nepal India have been completed and are operational, while the construction work of Butwal-Gorakhpur 400 kV cross-border transmission line has started.

It has also been agreed to proceed with the construction of Lamki-Bareli and Inaruwa-Purnia 400 kV transmission lines.

During the 11th meeting of Nepal-India Energy Secretary Level Joint Steering Committee, the two sides agreed to increase the capacity of the Dhalkebar-Muzaffar cross-border transmission line, which is operated as a first cross-border transmission line, to 1000 MW from existing capacity of 800 MW.

The JSC meeting instructed the JWG to finalise the investment modality to complete the construction of two more 400 kV cross-border transmission lines—Inarawa-Purniya and New Lumki (Dodohara)-Bareli transmission line between Nepal-India by 2027/28 and 2028/29 respectively. And all these projects will facilitate to export 10,000 MW power to India.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG\TRN

Devotees of a month-long Swosthani Bartakatha preparing to fetch holy water at the bank of Bagmati River in Pashupatinath temple.

Taylor Swift prepares for an epic journey to the Super Bowl

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 10



Taylor Swift's last song will still be ringing in the ears of thousands of fans at the Tokyo Dome on Saturday night when the singer is expected to rush to a private jet at Haneda airport that will take her on a time-zone-spanning journey to see her boyfriend, NFL star Travis Kelce, play in the Super Bowl in Las Vegas.

The prospect of this race against time, complete with police escort, crossing nine time zones and the international date line, has fired imaginations, and speculation, for weeks.

At Saturday night's concert, there was plenty of evidence of the unique cultural phenomenon that is the Swift-Kelce relationship, a nexus of professional football and the huge star power of Swift. In addition to sequined dresses celebrating Swift in the packed Tokyo Dome, there were Travis Kelce jerseys and hats and other gear celebrating his team, the Kansas City Chiefs. Some in Tokyo spent thousands of dollars to attend the pop superstar's concerts this week.

To call the worldwide scrutiny of Swift's travels intense is an understatement. Fans have tracked her jet. The planet-warming carbon emissions of her globe-trotting travels have been criticized. Officials have weighed in on her ability to park her jet in Las Vegas airports.

Even Japanese diplomats have gotten into the act. The Japanese Embassy in Washington posted on social media that she could make the Super Bowl in time, including in their statement three Swift song titles – "Speak Now", "Fearless" and "Red."

"If she departs Tokyo in the evening after her concert, she should comfortably arrive in Las Vegas before the Super Bowl begins," it said.

Swift has been crisscrossing the globe this week already. Before coming to Asia, she attended the Grammys in Los Angeles, winning her 14th Grammy and a record-breaking fourth Album of the Year award for "Midnights." The show was watched by nearly 17 million people. She also made a surprise announcement that her next album is ready to drop in April.

Gautamdas brings out 'Jhimikkai Pareli'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10



Singer Gautamdas Manandhar has brought his new music video 'Jhimikkai Pareli' that combines the features of both folk and modern romantic dancing beat.

Blue Berry Audio Video Company unveiled the video through Highlights Nepal Channel amidst a function here on Friday. Produced by Anju Manandhar, it contains female voice of popular singer Nisha Deshar, and lyric and music of Anil Shahi.

Manoj Maharjan and Hasana Maharjan have performed in the music video choreographed by Reshma Khadgi and Sumi Shahi. Singer Manandhar, who has been active in the music field for the last more than four decades, has also solo album 'Sadabahar' and crooned many songs in Nepal Bhasa

Tommy Hilfiger takes over the Oyster Bar in Grand Central for a joyous New York-centric fashion show

AP
New York, Feb. 10

Tommy Hilfiger threw himself a welcome home party Friday night at Grand Central's Oyster Bar with Questlove as his DJ and Jon Batiste serenading Anna Wintour on his melodica while a bevy of global celebrities looked on.

Turning the iconic restaurant into "The Tommy" club for a night, Hilfiger called his New York Fashion Week show "A New York Moment," rolling out roomy, '90s prep classics for the bash. The last time he hit town for fashion week was in September 2022, when his crowd braved rain for his "Tommy Factory" show at a Brooklyn drive-in theater.

This time, happy and dry underground beneath the transportation hub's vaulted ceilings, fans lined ramps for a glimpse of K-pop's Nayeon, her countryman Junho Lee, Indian actor Sonam Kapoor and various other friends of the brand: Sofia Richie Grainge and Damson Idris among them. Sylvester Stallone popped in at the end.

As the crowd sipped cocktails in booths, Hilfiger stuck to what he knows on models walking through: rugby shirts, blazers, chinos and varsity jackets in corduroy and herringbone. There were tailored women's coats in wool, checks and earth-toned tweeds, and chunky cable knits and mini-dress polos in cashmere. Hilfiger put some of his famous guests in pieces that were shoppable as he continued to embrace a "see now, buy now" approach to fashion shows.

During a preview Thursday at his Madison Avenue offices, Hilfiger ticked off his primary markets of today: Germany, France, Italy, England, Turkey, various parts of Scandinavia and Greece among them. "That business is now bigger than the U.S. business," he told The Associated Press. "We're going to bring it back in the states now because we have really focused a lot on international growth. And this is a statement we're making, that we're coming home, and we're taking it very seriously."

And who had the most fun during his New York return? Hilfiger himself. He sipped a martini as he posed with Stallone and others for photos after his finale, when Batiste played along to his hit "Freedom" as he walked through the crowd. The designer even briefly joined Questlove in his booth.

Treble Clef Back with Their Banger New Single

BY MANNU SHAHI



Formed in 2016, Treble Clef is a Damak based progressive rock trio led by guitarist and singer Asish Manpahang Rai. Influenced by international acts such as The Aristocrats, Karnivool, The Pineapple Thief, Uchu Conbini etc. the trio is amidst a handful successful bands to create such experimentally driven work from the eastern regions of Nepal.

With a series of line-up changes over the years, the present stack of members comprise Asish on vocals and guitars, Aswin Bhattarai on bass and Jay Ram Karki on drums. Some of the group's past band members include: Sabin Shrestha (drums), Dipen Rai (bass), Sudip Tamang (bass), Sandesh Gurung (drums) and Niroj Sundas (drums).

The trio debuted in the scene with their 2017's math/post-rock single 'Life', however, alongside Jay Ram on drums the song also featured collaborators Manjil Deuja on bass and prominent musical wizard Pawan Tandukar on piano. The instrumental flaunting Asish's ingenious guitar skills and complementing arrangement cemented Treble Clef as a promising new project. The same clique released another single a year later titled 'Sanidhya', with Asish joining in on vocal duties as well.

In June of 2018 the band released their third single 'Anyolta', trying out heavier riffs and louder dynamic swells, the eight minute long song was more apparently leaning towards progressive arrangement structures. 'Samip' was their fourth single premiering in 2021, after a short halt on publishing back to back, the song was a contrast to its predecessor. The slow and minimal composition highlighting the freedom of self-acceptance and being in alignment with the self was a pleasant listen especially right post-pandemic.

Around the same period the band established a separate YouTube channel for Treble Clef official, and since last year have started posting their material from this handle. Gathering some of their older and new tunes together the band published two of their EPs: five-tracks "Anyolta" and six-tracks "Sanidya", both a day apart from each other on January of 2023.

And recently on February 6, 2024 the trio released their new single 'Soch' and further unleashed announcements of the upcoming third album, the song is a presentation of Damak Music Circle (DMC), with Pineal Studio on audio production, Sound Fusion Studio on recording. The simple yet effective video is directed by Abishkar Joshi, with Rhythm Rai on DOP, Gaurav Bista on editing and coloring, Avhisekh Giri as the production manager.

The band describes the song as, "A deep dive into exploring one's illusions, challenging the dormant aspects of the mind. Ultimately, reflecting on the idea that we share a common divinity, akin to being demons, from the same divine source and ashes of a shared heritage. Beyond the veils of delusions and uncertainties lies a transformative journey towards heightened consciousness."

The song commences with the sound of a heartbeat and right after a sludgy odd meter pattern intro ensues, confident and in your face. Flowy guitar resolve cuts through the intro to pave way for the verse, gradual dynamic ascend in the pre-chorus with ornamenting drum fills and guitar lines. The chorus is the peak dynamic point in the song, employing a similar pattern like the intro.

The post-chorus break exhibits impressive chops from all three instrumentalists and an alteration of different patterns. The following section could be addressed as the bridge or even a second verse. Which leads the arrangement to the pre-chorus and ends the expedition high on the chorus. A recommended listen indeed!

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Acting on a hot tip can help you make a wise career decision at this time. While the attentive Moon in your 12th House of Secrets nudges fortunate Venus in your ambitious 10th house.

TAURUS: You're currently likely to have your finger on the pulse of your friend group's vibe. As the inquisitive Moon in your 11th House of Community supports pleasure planet Venus in your studious 9th house.

GEMINI: Building a surprising alliance over the course of the day can help you progress toward an important goal. Still, as the visible Moon in your 10th House of Reputation engages with volatile Uranus in your secretive 12th house.

CANCER: Deciding how much personal information to share with your friends will potentially be difficult today. While candid Mercury in your intimacy zone stumbles over exaggerated Jupiter in your social 11th house.

LEO: A personal relationship of yours could be causing trouble in your ongoing professional life. You potentially need to be clearer about your boundaries, but agonizing over how you should have seen this conflict coming.

VIRGO: Having fun with a loved one can lift your spirits today. Although you're likely in the mood for pleasure to begin with, your happiness is better off shared.

LIBRA: Having a beautiful and comfortable home is likely a priority for you at the moment. As the devoted Moon in your responsible 6th house harmonizes with aesthetic Venus in your domestic zone.

SCORPIO: Expressing yourself in conversation can clear recent emotional blockages in your relationships. While the passionate Moon in your individualistic 5th house encourages liberating Uranus in your partnership zone.

SAGITTARIUS: Comfort may be a high priority for you today. On top of that, indulgent doesn't automatically equal frivolous. When you think seriously about your health and wellness, there's probably something.

CAPRICORN: Putting things in a positive light is possible now. Although your chosen topic of conversation might usually be seen as a bit disruptive, you can read the room and accurately identify what your audience is willing to hear about the issue.

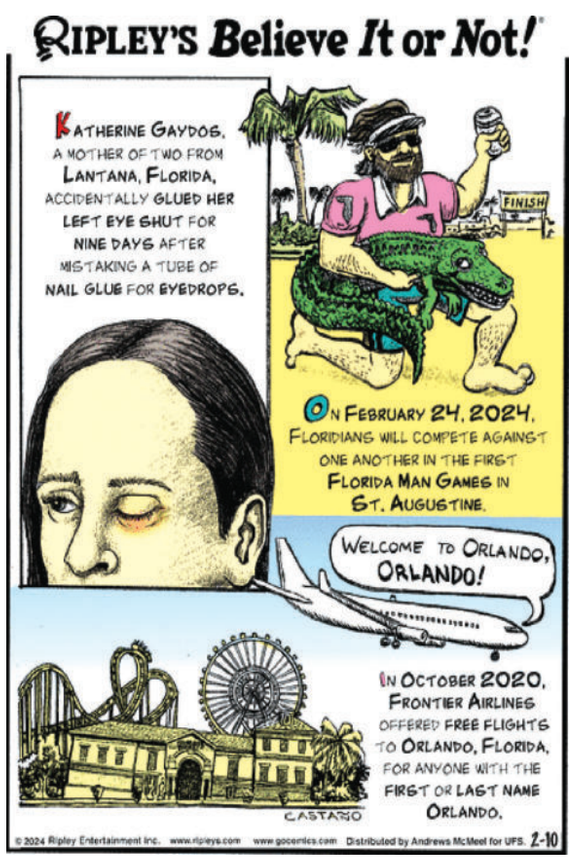
AQUARIUS: Ambitious plans for improving your home could be immediately tempered by your awareness of how much you're willing to spend. While the impulsive Moon meets restrictive Saturn in your finance zone.

PISCES: Socializing could be tons of fun for you at the moment. While the spontaneous Moon in your sign encourages quirky Uranus in your communication sector, you can probably think of just the right wild story to get everyone laughing.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Three half-centuries propel Nepal to victory over Canada in 2nd ODI

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10



PHOTO: BIKASH DWARE/TRN
Dev Khanal (left) crosses with Rohit Paudel during the second ODI match against Canada at TU International Cricket ground on Saturday.

The TU International Cricket Ground was vibrant after a long time on Saturday as Nepal defeated Canada in the second ODI and won the three-ODI series with one match in hand.

With three players crossing the 50-run mark, Nepal chased a target of 286 runs with 29 balls remaining in the loss of six wickets.

Thousands of fans thronged the TU Cricket Ground to witness the second match against Canada as the team was in good form after the players showed it in the first ODI on February 8.

Nepal defeated Canada by seven runs in the 1st ODI as the team defended a target of 225 runs. The final match of the series will be played on Monday.

Canada elected to bat first after winning the toss in the 2nd ODI. Openers Aaron Johnson and Navneet Dhaliwal were scary from the start and a huge pressure on Nepali bowlers.

Showcasing his bowling talent in the 2024 U19 World Cup recently, Aakash Chand, who debuted in the ODIs on Saturday, broke the first-wicket partnership in the 19th over as Dhaliwal (46 off 60) was caught behind the stumps. However, until then, the opening duo had taken the team to 94 runs.

Crossing the 50-run mark, Johnson followed Dhaliwal in the 23rd over after he was run out after scoring 65 off 62. Pargat Singh and Nicholas Kirton were unable to contribute enough as they departed after scoring 38 off 38 and 20 off 29 respectively.

However, as Nepal was looking to restrict Canada to a lower target, wicketkeeper-batsman Shreyas Movva made Nepal wait until the whole 50 overs ended. Before getting out in the final ball of the inning, Movva added 40 runs on the board in 42 deliveries and took the team to 285.

With Chand opening his account in men's international ODIs, Surya Tamang too opened his. Tamang debuted in the first ODI against Canada but was not able to take any wickets.

While Sompal Kami and Pawan Sarraf also bagged one wicket each, Kushal Malla and captain Rohit Kumar Paudel claimed two each.

Quality batting of Nepal

Replacing Kushal Bhurtel as the opener, Anil Kumar Sah, who scored the most runs in the PM Men's Cup 2024, opened Nepal's chase with a blast. Sah debuted for Nepal in 2018 but had been inactive on the international stage for quite some time.

It took him only 19 balls to get his half-century with seven fours and three sixes and announce his return to the national side. However, he departed in the 20th ball after getting struck leg before in the seventh over. It was the second-fastest fifty for a Nepali batsman in men's ODI.

Sah was the second wicket for Canada as wicketkeeper-batsman Aasif Sheikh (10 off 16) departed in the fifth over after getting caught while playing a drive on the off side.

Rohit Paudel and Dev Khanal, who captained the U19 side in the World Cup, then took everything in their hands after the 7th over. Starting with defence, the two batsmen showered boundaries in the latter overs.

Khanal, who was dropped once before crossing the 50-run mark, and Paudel guided the team to 214 runs in the 34th over. In 33.5 overs, Khanal departed after adding 76 off 81 on the board.

Bhim Sarki then tried maintaining a partnership with Paudel but he departed in the 40th over after scoring 23 off 21. Despite doing great and nearing his second ODI century, Paudel (87 off 101) was caught behind the stumps after a slight edge on the bat. Captain Paudel hit four maximums and eight fours. He was the player of the match as well.

Pawan Sarraf (14 off 8) was the sixth and final wicket that fell for Nepal in the 42nd over as he was also caught behind the stumps. Kushal Malla and Sompal Kami scored nine runs each and stayed not out as the target was chased in the first ball of the 46th over.



PHOTO: ACC VIA CAN
Sita Rana Magar with the player of the match award for her performance to defeat Hong Kong at Nepal's opening group match of the ACC Women's Premier Cup 2024 in Malaysia on Saturday.

Nepal begins ACC Women's Premier Cup defeating HK

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

Nepal's national women's cricket team began its promising campaign at the ACC Women's Premier Cup in Malaysia defeating Hong Kong by eight wickets on Saturday.

Electing to field first in the T20 tournament, the Hong Kong women's team was restricted to 93 runs in the loss of eight wickets by the end of the first innings.

Rubina Chhetry and Puja Mahato bagged two wickets each while Kabita Joshi and Sita Rana Magar claimed one each for Nepal. The bowlers kept Hong Kong under extreme pressure as the opponent batters could only hit five fours throughout the 20 overs.

Hong Kong's captain Chan Ka Ying Kary was the highest scorer for the side with 21 runs off 31 balls. Three other batters who scored in double figures for Hong Kong were Natasha Miles (11 off 19), Yasmin Daswani (15 off 21) and Maryam Bibi (19 off 20).

Shanzeen Shahzad, who came in at three, was given out for obstructing the field in 2.3 overs; she returned for a duck. Hong Kong, on the other hand, was unable to defend the paltry target. Nepal had to only lose two wickets as it chased the target with 35 balls remaining.

While opener Kabita Kunwar (4 off 12) departed early, Sita Rana Magar and captain Indu Barma did more than enough. Indu played a captain's inning before getting caught in the 13th over after scoring 40 off 33 with three fours and a six.

Rubina entered the crease after Indu departed at 87/2; however, she did not have to score. Sita, who finished the chase with a four towards deep covers, stayed not out at the score of 36 off 38. Sita was adjudged the player for the match for her performance with the bat as well as the ball.

Iqra Sahar took the wicket of Kabita and Chan Ka Man Betty sent Indu back to the pavilion for Hong Kong.

Nepal played its first group match against Hong Kong. The team looks forward to qualifying for the quarter-finals as the top two teams in Group D. Alongside Nepal and Hong Kong, the Maldives and Bhutan are in the group.

There are only three teams – Thailand, UAE and Indonesia, ranked above Nepal in the tournament.

In seven other matches on the opening day on Saturday, Thailand, UAE, Malaysia, Kuwait, Japan, Qatar and Bhutan also started their campaign with a win.

Nepal will play its second and third group matches against Bhutan and Maldives on February 11 and 13 respectively.

Defeating the Maldives on Saturday, Bhutan is at the top of the group table followed by Nepal with two points each. Bhutan got to the top based on the Net Run Rate as it defeated the Maldives by a large margin of 94 runs. Chasing a target of 125, Bhutan bundled out the Maldives' women's team at 30 runs in 18.1 overs.

SNIPPETS

Kohli not in remaining Tests against England

Rajkot (AP): India will play its three remaining cricket tests against England without star batter Virat Kohli. Kohli missed the first two tests, which the teams split, due to personal reasons, and the Board of Control for Cricket in India said Saturday that he would also miss the final three matches. It also said Ravindra Jadeja and KL Rahul would be subject to fitness clearances from its medical team ahead of the third test beginning next Thursday in Rajkot. Jadeja missed the second test due to a hamstring injury suffered in the first and Rahul has a right quadriceps injury. England won the first test by 28 runs and India the second by 106 runs.

Santiago Bernabeu to hold NFL game in 2025 season

Las Vegas (AFP): Days after confirming the NFL will host a game in Brazil next season, the league announced that the Bernabeu will be the venue for a Spanish fixture next year. NFL Commissioner Roger Goodell in a statement said, "We are proud to partner with Real Madrid C.F., a global brand, together with the City of Madrid and Comunidad de Madrid, to bring a spectacular regular season game to Spain at the world-class Santiago Bernabeu Stadium." Real Madrid president Florentino Perez hailed the move as a win for both his club and the NFL.

Argentina's China tour cancelled

Beijing (AFP): Argentina had announced a tour in China from March 18 to 26, during which it was to face Nigeria in Hangzhou and Ivory Coast in Beijing. But last week a high-profile friendly between Inter Miami and a select XI in Hong Kong sparked jeers and calls for refunds, after Messi did not take to the field, citing injury. Some nationalist politicians and outlets have interpreted the no-show in the 4-1 Inter Miami win – and Messi's subsequent appearance at a similar match in Japan – as a snub to China, without offering evidence. "Beijing does not plan, for the moment, to organise the match in which Lionel Messi was to participate," the Beijing Football Association, which oversees football in the capital, said in a press release Saturday. The Hangzhou match had already been cancelled on Friday evening. Messi has said it was "bad luck" that he could not play and that he hoped to return to the city.

Nepali youth team defeat's China's Yushu Youth 5-1

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 10



PHOTO: ANFA
Nepal's captain Manish Dangi (left) and the Chinese side captain Duojie Danzhou exchange pennants before the friendly match at Dasharath Rangasala on Saturday.

The Nepali under-23 men's football team defeated China's Yushu Youth 5-1 at a friendly match organised on the occasion of the Chinese New Year at Dasharath Rangasala on Saturday.

The match started after a cultural function as the two neighbours decided to the friendly as another way to strengthen Nepal and China's friendly ties.

Chen Song, Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary of the People's Republic of China to Nepal, and Ganesh Prasad Timilsina, chairman of the National Assembly, jointly inaugurated the football match.

Nepal started the match with aggression. With a goal ruled offside in the very first minute, Nepal opened its account in the second minute with a header.

Sanjeeb Bista scored the first goal by heading a cross by Ayush Ghalan. The next two goals were also a result of good headers.

Samir Tamang scored the second goal of the match in the 39th minute as he headed a cross by Chhiring Lama.

Within the first half, Nepal had chances to extend the lead to far more goals than that scored in the overall 90 minutes.

Meanwhile, the third goal came in the second half. Samir Tamang was again on the receiving end of a cross in the 54th minute to head his second and the team's third goal of the match. Chhiring made it 4-0 in the 63rd minute as he kicked the ball from just outside the 18-yard box to the back of the net. Nirajan Dhami scored the fifth goal for Nepal in the 75th minute.

The Chinese side was seen as determined to score goals until the very end, and the team was able to score a consolation goal in the 78th minute.

Substitute Zhaxi Pengcuo gave the Chinese side its only goal of the match after shooting a rebound from the goalpost.

PL bosses unconvinced by IFAB's 'blue card' plan

AFP
London, Feb. 10

It has been reported that blue cards will be shown to players, who would be sent to a 'sin-bin' for 10 minutes, as part of a new trial aimed at improving on-pitch behaviour.

At present, players shown a red card or two yellow cards are expelled for the rest of the game.

Sin bins have been used at grassroots level in England for dissent, but the trial could also include cynical fouls.

Reports say that football's lawmakers IFAB have delayed releasing information about the proposed trial following talks with world governing body FIFA.

It is understood that the trial phase will not take place in top-level football to avoid players being in competitions with different rules concurrently.

But Klopp was among several Premier League managers to express concerns about the proposal.

"I think everything what the actual situation shows is we should keep it as simple as somehow possible, for the referees as well," the German said Friday.

"It's a difficult job. I think the introduction of a blue card would just give more opportunities to fail as well.

"The discussion will be: 'It was a blue card, should it have been a yellow card? Now it's 10 minutes off. In the good old times it would have been a red card or only a yellow'.

"It doesn't sound like a fantastic idea in the first moment but actually I can't remember the last fantastic idea (which) came from these guys, if they ever had one. I am 56 and, pah, never."

Postecoglou said the plan could be another misstep by football's authorities after the controversial introduction of the widely criticised VAR system.

"I don't think people will be surprised by my thoughts on it. I struggle to understand this urgency all of a sudden to bring in new things," he said.

"I don't know if there's that much wrong with the game as I see it. My biggest issue with the game right now is that VAR has changed the experience, whether you're a player, a manager or a supporter.

"Beyond that, I don't know why a different colour card is going to make any difference."

Arsenal boss Mikel Arteta called for the proposals to be rigorously tested before blue cards are given the green light.

"We've got a lot going on with decisions, with technology. I don't know if we are ready for that yet," he said.

"Who knows (if it is a good idea). Hopefully, it's going to be tested very well before they introduce it at this level."

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:45 am, Sunset at 5:52 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province and Karnali Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 20 - 22°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	24.4	6.1	0.0
Dadeldhura	15.8	3.5	0.0
Dhangadi	25.8	8.6	0.0
Birendranagar	23.5	6.7	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.0	8.4	0.0
Jumla	17.0	-6.0	0.0
Ghorahi	23.1	6.7	0.0
Pokhara	24.0	7.6	0.0
Bhairahawa	24.9	5.8	0.0
Simara	24.7	7.0	0.0
Kathmandu	21.3	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.0	7.3	0.0
Taplejung	19.9	5.5	0.0
Dhankuta	24.5	7.3	0.0
Biratnagar	25.9	7.5	0.0
Jomsom	12.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.0	11.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.0	5.0	0.0*
Janakpur	27.5	8.2	0.0*
Jiri	15.7	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 11, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.56	Rs. 133.16
Euro	1	Rs. 142.74	Rs. 143.39
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.11	Rs. 167.87
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 151.41	Rs. 152.10
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.29	Rs. 86.68
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.52	Rs. 98.97
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.47	Rs. 98.92
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.87	Rs. 8.91
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.35	Rs. 36.52
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.69	Rs. 3.71
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.09	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.82	Rs. 27.95
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.96	Rs. 10.00
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.65	Rs. 12.71
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.15	Rs. 19.23
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.31	Rs. 432.25
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.64	Rs. 353.23

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54